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SATURDAY, JULY 18, 2026

IRAN ATTACKS US ALLIES, DAMAGES POWER AND WATER DESALINATION PLANT IN KUWAIT

Bridges hit, Chabahar port tower falls as US escalates Iran offensive

Associated Press
Dubai, July 17

THE UNITED States expanded its airstrike campaign against Iran early Friday by hitting more bridges, energy sites and collapsing a tower at a key Iranian port, backing up US President Donald Trump's threats to start striking infrastructure to pressure Tehran to ease its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran launched missile attacks against US-allied nations in the West Asia, including Qatar, a mediator in the war, and Kuwait, where a power and water desalination plant — vital infrastructure in the desert nation — was damaged.

The interim ceasefire agreed to last month has collapsed, and the region has endured days of back-and-forth attacks by the US and Iran as they battle for control of the strait.

Iranian officials say recent US strikes have killed dozens of people and wounded hundreds of others, with new casualties reported in Friday's strikes.

The US airstrikes hit bridges overnight into Friday in Iran's southern Hormozgan province, killing at least seven people, Iranian state television reported. The attacks hit Bandar Khamir, a city on Iran's coast on the Strait of Hormuz.

The damaged portion of a bridge in Bandar Khamir, Hormozgan province of Iran, Friday. REUTERS

The highway and railway bridge strikes appeared aimed at cutting off Bandar Abbas, Iran's main port, from roads leading into the Islamic Republic's central region onward to Tehran, the capital.

While other routes still are open, the US strikes could expand further, potentially disrupting both the movement of military materiel and goods needed for Iran's 90 million people. Iran also acknowledged "attacks on power infrastructure" during the US airstrike campaign for the first time Friday when its Energy Ministry issued a call for people to use less power in southern provinces.

The US military's Central Command said it hit dozens of targets in its latest airstrikes, which concluded at dawn Friday, the sixth night in a row of American attacks.

The strikes also collapsed a tower at Iran's Chabahar port on the Gulf of Oman, a key trade route for landlocked, neighbouring Afghanistan, the state-run IRNA news agency reported.

Chabahar port, which Iran had been running with support from India, has been a repeated target of American airstrikes.

Iran described the tower as overseeing commercial traffic into the port. However, Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard also operates at ports across the country. As of 6 am Friday, the US strikes had killed at least 38 people and wounded more than 400 in Iran, Health Ministry spokesperson Hossein Kermanpour said.

On Friday, Qatar twice warned the public to take shelter as a barrage of Iranian missiles targeted the nation. People heard explosions overhead as air defences fired to intercept the missiles. Qatar's Interior Ministry said falling debris wounded a child.

Iran also targeted Bahrain and Kuwait early Friday. In Kuwait, authorities said Iran attacked a power and water desalination plant, causing widespread damage to the station. About 90 per cent of the country's drinking water comes from desalination.

Kuwait said it extinguished the blaze and was working to assess the damage and get the station working again.

Jordan's military said it intercepted three incoming missiles Friday morning launched by Iran. Explosions also could be heard Friday morning in Irbil and Sulaymaniyah in northern Iraq's semiautonomous Kurdish region as air defences targeted incoming fire.

Xi pitches China as leader of new global AI order, challenges dominance of US

Chinese President Xi Jinping waves as he arrives at the opening ceremony of the World AI Conference in Shanghai, Friday. REUTERS

Reuters
Shanghai, Beijing, July 17

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping on Friday cast Beijing as the champion of a new global AI order, using China's premier tech conference to promote open-source technology and challenge US influence over the rules governing the fast-moving sector.

In a speech to the opening ceremony of the World Artificial Intelligence Conference (WAIC) in Shanghai, Xi urged countries to seize the "historic opportunity" of open-source AI, and pledged to help developing nations build AI capabilities, warning against the emergence of "new historical injustices" from unequal access to the technology.

The remarks amounted to Xi's clearest articulation yet of China's ambition to shape global AI governance, framing its open-source models as a global public good and positioning Beijing as an alternative to Washington at a pivotal moment in the race for technological leadership.

Comparing AI's significance to the invention of the steam engine and electricity, Xi outlined a vision in which China shares AI technology and expertise with countries across the Global South, while leading global efforts to create standards governing the emerging technology.

The speech pitched China's AI coalition as a rival to the U.S.-led "Pax Silica" international initiative to secure global AI and critical mineral supply chains, though Xi avoided naming Washington.

Chinese state media has increasingly portrayed Beijing's AI strategy as a response to what it calls a U.S.-led attempt to erect an "AI Iron Curtain."

In a commentary published on Thursday, Yuyuan Tantian, a prominent social media account affiliated with state broadcaster CCTV, said China was seeking to build "another order" by "pooling the strength of all humanity and all countries to build an open-source, all-factor AI ecosystem."

The WAIC conference underlined the shifting AI landscape, with Chinese open-weight AI models making rapid gains against proprietary systems from U.S. companies such as OpenAI and Anthropic.

Beijing-based startup Moonshot AI on Friday unveiled Kimi K3, which it described as the world's largest open AI model by parameter count, a month after the U.S. government abruptly pulled Anthropic's frontier-class AI models due to security concerns.

Reuters reported earlier this month that Beijing is weighing restrictions on overseas access to some of China's leading AI models, highlighting the growing tension between its promotion of open-source AI and an increasingly stringent national security agenda.

Xi also called for AI systems to remain under human control and urged countries to establish early-warning and emergency-response mechanisms to manage AI risks, in his clearest remarks to date on AI safety.

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FORMAL AND UNORGANISED SECTOR

EPFO reform: Govt works on new pension plan for all

Plan with 2 options: annuity, systematic withdrawal

Ravi Dutta Mishra & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 17

THE GOVERNMENT is working on a new contributory pension scheme for unorganised and formal sector workers that would accumulate contributions over time, and be invested in long-term government-backed securities, with annual crediting of interest. At the age of 60 years, the scheme may allow the proposed "Target Retirement Sum (TRS)" to be converted into pension, based on prevailing annuity and interest rates, a senior government official told *The Indian Express*.

The scheme, part of the 3.0 reforms phase of the retirement fund body Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), will cover existing members and those excluded from the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS). It is likely to adopt a defined contribution framework and allow contributions from multiple sources: workers themselves, employers, government co-contributions for workers in the lower wage segment, aggregators in the case of gig and platform workers, and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Flexibility based on age, pension goal

The scheme will cover existing members and those excluded from the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS). A Target Retirement Sum will be dynamically fixed based on the member's chosen pension goal and expected retirement age.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi flags off the first hydrogen-powered train, between Jind and Sonipat, at Jind railway station in Haryana, Friday. PTI

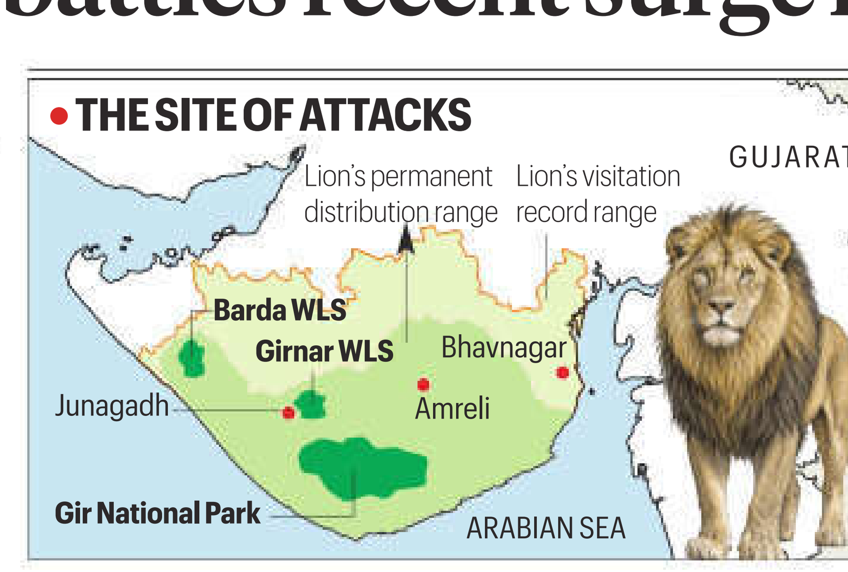
RELATED REPORT, PAGE 8

EXPRESS special

31 lions captured, 7 declared 'maneaters', Gujarat battles recent surge in attacks

Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, July 17

THE GUJARAT Forest Department has decided to rope in the Wildlife Institute of India (WII) to conduct a study on possible changes in lion behaviour, among other things, after at least nine attacks by the big cat since last month in the state, leaving six dead. In response, the authorities have captured around 31 lions and relocated them, as well as declared seven as "maneaters", which means they will remain in captivity — an alarming number for such a short period in Gujarat.



Kalubhai Parmar, 45, a maldhari or cowherd, lives in Garajiya village of Bhavnagar. The village falls in Palitana taluk known for both Jain temples and for lion sightings. But nothing had prepared Parmar for what happened on the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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EPFO

corporate social responsibility (CSR) or third-party funds, the officials said.

The EPFO proposes to give the flexibility to the worker at the age of 55 years to decide the purpose for his or her retirement savings. "Till that time, it will operate like PF, you keep on accumulating. At that stage when you are retiring, it converts into an annuity or a systematic withdrawal plan," the official said.

Under the proposed pension plan, each member will have an individual pension account. "The system will compute the proposed Target Retirement Sum (TRS) dynamically based on the member's chosen pension goal and expected retirement age. Members will have personalised dashboards showing total contributions, real-time corpus status, and progress towards the TRS for applicable schemes," another official said.

The system will project the required contribution amount and frequency to achieve the declared TRS. "Adjustments to TRS will be allowed and contribution requirements could then be recomputed accordingly. The system will accept and categorise contributions from multiple sources such as members, employers, or third-parties and update the member's pension balance," the official said.

When asked if this would be along the lines of the National Pension System (NPS), one of the officials cited above said the NPS is "purely annuity based, while the proposed pension scheme will be more flexible, risk free and based on real and not notional returns". "We want to make it similar to the PF which continues with only the contributions being stopped because you are retired, so you will not have any contribution. It will then be a systematic withdrawal plan on the basis of your expected monthly pension payout. So, it can be equal to the interest that you want, in which case, the corpus will remain the same. For example, if 8% interest is declared and that 8% over Rs 1 crore is translating to Rs 8 lakh, so you divide it by 12 and that becomes your pension payout every month," the official explained.

Elaborating further, the official said, "If you want higher in the initial stage, then it will be a drawdown from your principal. So, based on your longevity, you estimate that in 20 years you want to have a good pension, you can increase your drawdown. At the same time, you can reduce your drawdown. If you reduce your drawdown, your interest will get added to your principal. So, towards the later part, it becomes almost like an inflation-linked plan where towards the later part, you can have a higher payout. This is what we are thinking about."

The flexibility to decide the amount for pension payouts or the drawdown will be given to the member. "The EPFO 3.0 system will allow users to simulate pension amounts based on parameters such as age, corpus, interest rate, and retirement age. It will also include additional input fields for voluntary contributions and contribution frequency. The system will provide inflation-adjusted projections as an optional feature. The estimated monthly pension, projected corpus at retirement, and comparative graphs will be displayed to the member, allowing multiple scenario comparisons for decision making taking into account variable contributions and multiple employment scenarios," the official said.

The scheme also proposes family and survivor pensions for spouse, children, and orphans funded through a pooled "Family Benefit Fund", managed on actuarial principles, the official said. Members of EPF, GPF, and other provident funds could also be allowed to transfer balances into the new pension initiative to enhance retirement savings, the official added.

The EPFO 3.0 reforms will bring new tech features and an upgradation to the core banking solution (CBS), and pave the way for PF contributions for all unorganised sector workers and gig workers, in line with the Code on Social Security that brings gig and platform workers into the social security net for the first time. The Code mandates aggregator contributions of 1-2% of annual turnover for social security, with the total contribution not exceeding 5% of the amount payable by the aggregator.

The retirement fund models of other countries such as Singapore are being studied to incorporate the best practices, the official said. Singapore's social security scheme, Central Provident Fund (CPF), a deferred annuity scheme, sets aside savings not just for retirement but also for housing and healthcare. Singaporeans do not rely on individual CPF contributions alone for their retirement income as apart from a contribution of 20% of the salary to CPF, individual efforts are supplemented by employers, loved ones and the government, as per the information on the Singapore government website. Unlike pension schemes in other countries, CPF members earn an interest of up to 6% for those aged 55 and above, and 5% for those aged below 55.

While the new social security coverage scheme will make use of the EPFO's digital infrastructure, the nodal agency for the implementation of the social security scheme is yet to be finalised by the Ministry of Labour and Employment.

As the EPFO expects around 2.5 crore gig workers and building and other construction workers (BOCW) over the next five years, the scheme is also being designed keeping in mind their inclusion into social security coverage for the first time. The scheme will incorporate "one-to-many mapping" where one UAN (Universal Account Number) will be registered with multiple employers and aggregators, showing total PF and pension contributions from all sources for these workers while maintaining their employer-wise breakdowns.

The EPFO system plans to allow third-party contributions like NGOs, individuals, donor organisations, CSR and track all contributions under each UAN with a configurable upper limit.

Lions

morning of July 6.

He was feeding his cows when a lion suddenly emerged and pinned him down. Parmar first resigned himself to death, but when the lion tried to grab his neck, something came over him and the 45-year-old put his hand inside its mouth. "Had I allowed it to grab my neck, it would have killed me within a second," he says.

One hand in the lion's mouth, Parmar began to stroke the lion's neck with the other. The videos of Parmar doing so made by fellow villagers would later go viral. Says Parmar: "This was my first such encounter with a lion. They had never come into the village before. I only thought that if I calm it down, it may release me. As I continued to stroke it, it opened its mouth and I pulled out my hand. Then, after we were in this

position for nearly 10 minutes, with the lion sitting on my legs, it got up and I ran home."

Escaping with two broken fingers and a gash on his neck, Parmar, who has six children and rears six cows, says he doesn't blame the lion. "The animal harms us only if we harass it."

As concern grows over the lion attacks, this is what experts underline too, as do *maldharis* such as Parmar who refer to the animal as *saavaj* and have lived in close proximity with it for generations. However, as expanding human imprint makes the chances of these encounters more common, that understanding is wearing thin.

Gujarat remains the only natural habitat of Asiatic lions in the world, with the core area being the Gir forest, covering Junagadh and Gir Somnath districts in Saurashtra.

Principal Chief Conservator of Forests and Chief Wildlife Warden, Gujarat, Jaipal Singh says: "The attacks seem to have happened for different reasons, some of them due to lions being harassed. But we can't pinpoint the exact reason (behind the surge)."

While the 31 captured lions have been relocated to areas where there are no lion prides, Singh adds: "We do not release these confirmed maneaters." He puts the number of maneaters, who are eventually put in zoos, at six or seven, adding that they want the study with the WII "to understand and guide us on this change of behaviour (of lions) and the precautions to be taken". Singh also underlines that none of the lions shifted or declared maneater was involved in more than one attack.

A senior forest officer says what is particularly worrying is that in many cases, the maneaters have "consumed" people. "Generally, humans are not a part of a lion's diet," the officer says.

However, Rajkot-based Bhushan Pandya, a former member of the Gujarat State Board for Wildlife, says the designation as maneaters is "unreasonable". "As per guidelines of the National Tiger Conservation Authority, a tiger is considered a maneater only when it repeatedly kills people and consumes them. Not if it does it once. If a lion has killed a person after the latter harassed it, it should not be called a maneater. This is being done to pacify people, but it is not proper for wildlife management."

Dushyant Vasavada, who worked as Chief Conservator of Forests (Junagadh Wildlife Circle) before his retirement, says capturing a lion can also "shatter" a pride. However, he says, the authorities have their hands tied. "A lion is captured as a precautionary measure. What if the same lion is not captured and it kills another human being? It is a process. There is no other way."

Are lions to blame?

No, says Vasavada, putting the blame squarely on humans. "Man has gone into the area of the lion and is disturbing it. In most of the reported cases, lions were harassed. In Liliya, a youth was killed when he tried to capture mating lions on his phone. In Palitana, the lion attacked (Parmar) after it was harassed in a nearby village where it had captured a prey. In Girnar, a lion killed a boy after people flashed lights at it," says Vasavada.

Forest Minister Arjun Modhwadia also says that in almost all the recent cases of lion attacks, the harassment was from the human side, adding that in the Liliya incident, the friends of the man killed would be investigated. The Forest Department has "zero tolerance" in such cases, he adds. "Earlier, action was taken against a person for holding 'lion shows' (the practice of ensuring a lion does not move away to give tourists a good sighting)."

Too many lions?

Vasavada dismisses this contention. "Lions have expanded their territory only when there have been favourable conditions," he says, be it safety or food, underlining that the animal usually does not venture into populated areas.

As per the government's five-yearly Lion Population Estimation, the number of lions in Gujarat increased from 674 in 2020 to 891 in 2025. More crucially, the core area holds just 394 of them, with 497 disbursed in satellite populations in different parts of the region.

What's the solution

Pandya says the Forest Department should resume mobile patrolling at night to check activities like 'lion shows', often organised by owners of the fly-by-night hotels. He also advocates giving wider powers to forest officials. "Scientific management of Greater Gir (lion landscape outside its core area) is required."

GROUND report

‘Can’t fill the form... help us’: Race against time for BLOs in East Delhi where digitisation average is among the worst

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 17

BLOs Vivek (left) and Vinay during the ongoing SIR drive. PRAVEEN KHANNA

WITH JUST 13.81% of forms digitised, East Delhi is among the worst performing districts in the Capital in terms of digitising the enumeration forms filled out by electors as the Election Commission holds the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in the city. Digitisation average across districts in Delhi is pegged at around 21%, according to the data provided by the Chief Electoral Office (CEO).

From unnumbered houses, confusing addresses to an average elector’s inability to fill the form — booth level officers or BLOs in the East Delhi district say that they are facing a race against time to make sure no eligible electors are left out.

The Election Commission of India earlier this week extended the deadline for the ongoing door-to-door visits to August 8, giving BLOs more time to distribute and collect enumeration forms in Delhi.

It’s a humid July afternoon. As Vivek Kumar, an English teacher and BLO of Mangal Bazaar’s Block F in East Delhi, enters the street where he is supposed to distribute enumeration forms, he seeks help from passersby to locate the addresses on his list.

As he enters one of the houses, he sifts through hundreds of enumeration forms in his backpack. He puts his register, in which he notes all necessary details, and other stuff on the floor.

Explaining the process to the residents, he gives a suggestion, “Please get the forms photocopied so that you can make mistakes.” Most enumeration forms he gets, he adds, are riddled with mistakes. To place the residents of the house, he scans the list — the woman in the house is on Page 18 of his list, while her son is on Page 31. Around 45 minutes have passed and they realise that the woman’s husband is assigned to another BLO.

Eyes on the list, Vivek is explaining to another resident on a call on how to find his father's details on the Election Commission Information Network or ECINET app. Multitasking has become necessary during hectic routines. He packs his stuff and makes way to the next home. Annie Gomes, the next elector on the list, is not at her house, and the neighbours are not sure if she lives here or not. “We get a lot of such cases where the owner of the house has moved, but their vote is still registered here,” says Vivek.

Around 10 km away is the Chilla Village near the Yamuna. A foul stench pervades the entire colony as open drains remain clogged with garbage. BLO Vinay Kumar is also facing a slew of challenges. As he knocks on the door of the house of 55-year old Brahm Chand to collect the form he had given a couple days back, the resident gives a confused look. “*Humse nahi bhara jaave form, tu bharde humara*. (We are not able to fill this... you please fill on our behalf).”

A tired Vinay sits inside the house and ends up spending more than 30 minutes as he fills the forms of the family of five. The 31-year old explains that most people in the village don't have fixed addresses. "While villagers might know each other, so many people are tenants. Sometimes, 15 families are renting out different rooms in one house... it gets very confusing," Vinay says, adding he has to fill out the forms of most people since they don't know how to read or write. Next, he goes and sits at the verandah of the house — a lot of people come to clear doubts. "If I can't place myself on electoral rolls, will I be sent to Bangladesh?" asks 60-year old Anisha Khatum, who has a voter ID, but is not able to find herself or any relative in the 2002 electoral list. A neighbour tells her not to worry. She can show her widower's pension slip when she is sent a notice, she is told.

An election official explains, "In areas like Chilla Village and Kotla Village, a lot of the electors are labourers who are uneducated and don't understand the process. Also, many of them don't have any proof of where their parents lived since they even moved around and lived on rent."

EYE ON SECURING MAJORITY FOR WOMEN QUOTA LAW AND DELIMITATION BILL

Govt puts draft law seeking removal of 'tainted' ministers on backburner

House panel defers adoption of report on 130th Constitution Amendment Bill

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 17

FOCUSED ON gathering the required majority for clearing the Constitution (131st Amendment Bill) for implementing the Women's Reservation law and the Delimitation Bill, the BJP-led Union government is not likely to bring the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill that seeks to remove ministers arrested for serious offences for 30 consecutive days, sources said.

Sources said the BJP has made the rollout of the Women's Reservation law and the Delimitation Bill its "priority" and does not want "other contentious Bills" to be pushed in the Monsoon Session beginning Monday.

"Securing a two-thirds majority for the women's quota law and the Delimitation Bill is the top priority as of now," said a senior BJP MP.

According to the sources, Opposition parties such as the DMK and the NCP(SP), with which the BJP has been in discussion for a favourable stand on the Delimitation Bill, have conveyed to the government that they cannot support the contentious Bill.

On Friday, the Joint Committee of Parliament examining the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill was expected to adopt the report but deferred it, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources in the NDA said even the TDP had reservations on some clauses in the Bill.

In the committee meeting, its chairperson, BJP's Aparajita Sarangi, is learnt to have agreed to wider consultations on the contentious clauses.

"The committee wants to get the Opposition also on board for adopting the report unanimously. So, the chairperson was keen to give more time," said a source in the BJP.

It is learnt that the Opposition MPs in the House panel — AIMIM's Asaduddin Owaisi and NCP(SP)'s Supriya Sule — and YSRCP's Niranjan Reddy were prepared to give a dissent note to the report but dropped it as the committee was ready for a wider consultation.

Most members of the panel from the Opposition, including the Congress, boycotted the proceedings, arguing that their participation was pointless as the ruling party would override their concerns and use the panel as a rubber stamp to clear the Bill.

The Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025, provides for the removal of a minister if he/she is accused of an offence punishable with five or more years of imprisonment and has been arrested and detained for 30 consecutive days. The removal, according to the proposed Bill, can be directed by the President or Governor upon the advice of the Prime Minister or the Chief Minister, or automatically on the 31st day of detention.

The panel, led by BJP's Aparajita Sarangi, is learnt to have agreed to have wider consultations on contentious clauses

Removal or suspension

It is learnt that during Friday's meeting, many members raised their apprehension over replacing the word "removal" with "suspension" — a suggestion that came during the consultation with the different parties and premier law universities — as it may dilute the purpose of the Bill.

Although allies like the TDP have backed the Bill, saying the proposed legislation could strengthen the institutional mechanism for combating corruption involving people holding high offices and bring in accountability, it also wants provisions preventing misuse of the law to be incorporated, sources said.

The final report is expected to incorporate the suggestions from the panel members for avoiding any misuse of the law. The committee is also expected to recommend curbs or a threshold regarding the nature of the crime for the provisions of the proposed law to apply.

But the ruling party members in the panel are learnt to have rejected the Opposition's argument that the provisions in the proposed law are undemocratic, anti-federal and contradict the bedrock principle of natural justice by punishing public representatives purely based on custody rather than conviction.

Murmu to embark on week-long visit to Eastern Europe

Divya A
New Delhi, July 17

PRESIDENT DROUPADI Murmu will embark on a week-long state visit to Moldova, Romania and North Macedonia, starting July 19, to strengthen ties with the Eastern and central European countries.

"President Droupadi Murmu will visit Moldova on July 20 at the invitation of the President Maia Sandu. This is the first ever visit by an Indian President to Moldova," said the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Friday.

During the first leg of her three-nation visit, President Murmu will hold delegation level talks with her counterpart, and meet President of the Moldovian Parliament, Igor Grosu. She will also interact with members of the Moldova-India Parliamentary Friendship Group as well as the Indian diaspora there, and address a business forum.

"There is good scope for mutually beneficial cooperation in the areas of agriculture, healthcare and pharmaceuticals, IT and education," added the MEA statement.

In the second part of the trip, Murmu will land in North Macedonia for two days from July 21. This also marks the first ever visit by an Indian President to the nation. Murmu will hold bilateral talks with President Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova, meet Prime Minister Hristijan Mickoski, and address the Assembly of North Macedonia. Both sides are keen on deepening economic ties in sectors like agriculture, pharmaceuticals, science and technology, IT and ITES.

The final leg of the tour will see President Murmu land in Romania — which will see a visit by an Indian President after three decades — on July 23. She will meet her counterpart Nicușor Dan and interim PM Ilie Bolojan. President Murmu will also address India-Romania Business Forum and will interact with the Indian diaspora there.

SC: Name deletion under SIR does not mean automatic loss of citizenship

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 17

REITERATING THAT the Election Commission of India (ECI) is not the final authority to determine citizenship, the Supreme Court in oral remarks on Friday said that deletion from the electoral roll following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) would not result in automatic loss of citizenship status. The status will continue for other purposes until final adjudication by the concerned authority.

A three-judge bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant pointed out that it had already made this clear in its judgment upholding the Bihar SIR.

The comments came as the bench, also comprising Justices Joymala Bagchi and V Mohana, was hearing a plea seeking its intervention to streamline the hearings before the tribunals set up to hear appeals against exclusions from the voters list.

Senior Advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for petitioner Prasenjit Bose, said that only about 38,000 appeals have been disposed of so far by the 19 Appellate Tribunals and that about 33.5 lakh are pending. He said that of the 38,000 which were disposed of, 70 per cent were allowed, and their names were restored.

BLOs assist people in filling and verifying forms as part of the Election Commission's SIR exercise, in Ranchi, Thursday. PTI

"There is one more issue. It's about the consequences of the deletions being sustained... Now the 30 per cent which were not allowed, they will challenge in writs or whatever. But the consequence of a deletion is that between May 17 and now, three notifications have come, maybe others will come, saying if you have been deleted from the SIR list, you lose out on PDS which you were getting earlier, they are excluding you from Annapurna Yojana...," he said.

Justice Bagchi said the point was flagged before the bench a few days ago as well. "We are conscious of this. And we indicated that in our judgment in Bihar SIR. We made clear that there is a corresponding duty on the ECI, as soon as it takes a decision, that a citizenship is not in their estimation, correctly assessed and he (stands) deleted from the voters list but the status continues... the ECI has a corresponding duty to refer it to the ministry or the concerned central government department for an adjudication under the citizenship Act. Unless that is done, for other purposes, the status must go on."

Sankaranarayanan said, "I think to be fair, I don't think either they disclosed or we apprehended at all that all these other welfare schemes which are available to people who reside here would also be withdrawn. I don't think that was apprehended by your lordships because then I presume your lordships could add one sentence saying, while it's being adjudicated, please don't take other civil rights which are available to citizens."

On this, Justice Bagchi said, "Our judgment is clear – ECI is not a constitutional authority with regard to status under Art 9, 10, 11 and 12." Sankaranarayanan said, "but the problem today is it is being used as that".

Justice Bagchi said, "There are two things, one - whether there is confusion in the law, two - whether the law is correctly implemented. In the first, we do not see any confusion. Our judgment is clear. ECI has control and superintendence over the electoral roll and the powers... and can decide not to include someone over doubts that he is not citizen of the country. That does not result in loss of status of citizenship per se."

Sankaranarayanan said, "What I'm saying is that of the 34 lakh appeals...if only 38,000 have been disposed of, there are 33.5 lakh that are still pending. Now, those 33.5 lakh have all these things being withdrawn from them, while their appeals are pending, where at least the track record shows 70% of the appeals have been allowed. So, in the interregnum, the consequence of the appeal not being heard...."

The senior counsel said, "You have taken away the vote. Municipal elections are in October. That deprivation will continue until the appeals are heard. So, we are only suggesting mechanism should try and ensure some transparency and accountability and to assist those 19 Tribunals...".

Pointing to the removal of those deleted from the Annapurna Yojana, the plea said, "The consequences of wrongful deletion extend beyond electoral participation and directly affect access to welfare benefits."

The court said it will hear it along with other West Bengal SIR matters.

'Grieving' elephant that chased vehicles for 3 yrs after truck killed its herd captured

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, July 17

AN ELEPHANT that lost all other members of its herd in a highway accident in the Chittoor district of Andhra Pradesh three years ago, and subsequently went on a rampage raiding crops, attacking livestock and leaving villagers terrorised in the Palamaner forest division, was finally captured and taken to an elephant camp for veterinary and behavioural assessments.

Officials described the elephant as "grieving", making its behaviour unpredictable and potentially dangerous to people as well as to itself.

The sub-adult tusker was part of a herd of four, including two sub-adult males, one female, and a calf. On the night of June 14, 2023, a speeding truck rammed into the herd while the elephants were crossing the Bengaluru-Chennai National Highway (NH-4) near Palamaner. Three elephants died, but this one escaped without any injuries.

"This elephant lost its herd and became a grieving, solitary animal. Since the tragedy, it has frequently returned to the area where the accident occurred, crossing the NH-4 at unpredictable times. It became a threat not only to people on the highway, but also to itself as the possibility of another accident was high," Conservator of Forests, Anantapur Circle, R Yashoda Bai, told *The Indian Express*.

"It was not eating properly, chewing up garbage and trash, and its health was deteriorating. Villagers were also complaining about it. It had to be rescued," Yashoda Bai added.

The forest department was continuously monitoring the elephant's movements and behaviour, and had spent considerable resources to keep it and the people who live in the area safe, officials explained.

'I thought I was going to die'

During one of its many run-ins with people, the elephant fell on top of Palamaner Forest Division Forest Section Officer S Sukumar.

"I thought I was going to die. Imagine an elephant falling on you," he said, recalling the incident.

The incident happened on September 13, 2025, when the elephant was aggressively pursuing vehicles and people on NH-4. Sukumar and forest department tracker B Hari were trying to drive the elephant away when, even though it initially ran towards the forest, it suddenly turned around and charged at the duo.

In the subsequent chase, the elephant slipped and fell on Sukumar. After a few minutes, the confused elephant found its footing, stood up and ran away. A seriously injured Sukumar was admitted to a hospital and spent weeks recovering. Months later, this week, he took part in the operation to capture the elephant.

Since all other members of its herd were killed in an accident on NH-4 in Andhra Pradesh's Chittoor in 2023, the elephant (centre) frequently returned to the area. EXPRESS

G Subburaj, District Forest Officer, Chittoor, said that it took months of monitoring and planning to capture the elephant safely.

"This young elephant would have been happy and safe with its herd. Instead, it was lonely and disoriented with frequent mood swings," he said.

While the elephant showed aggression towards humans, it fled when forest guards or trackers approached it on "kumki" elephants — trained captive elephants used to capture or rescue wild elephants.

"We realised that it ran away because these [kumki] elephants were older and bigger. When we used young elephants of the same age as this elephant, it approached and tried to be friendly. It appeared that the young kumki elephants were trying to console him. This helped a lot in planning and managing the operation to capture it," said Yashoda Bai.

Since the 2023 accident, the elephant had continued to chase people, particularly two-wheeler riders, besides repeatedly damaging crops. It had also become a risk to itself on the NH-4.

Sophisticated operation

The Forest Department submitted proposals seeking permission to capture the elephant. After detailed examination of the field situation, permission was accorded by the Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife) and the Chief Wildlife Warden under the provisions of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

Following approval, the Forest Department constituted an Advisory Committee, Field Capture Team, veterinary teams, tracking teams, logistics teams and communication teams. Using drones and thermal sensor cameras, continuous monitoring of the elephant was undertaken to confirm its identity, study its behaviour, map its movement pattern, and identify suitable capture sites.

Risk assessments were carried out to identify safe darting locations, emergency evacuation routes and transportation logistics. Simultaneously, coordination meetings were held with the police, Revenue, Health, Animal Husbandry, Fire Services and other line departments to ensure seamless support during the operation.

It was also decided to deploy five trained Kumki elephants from the Musalimadugu Elephant Camp, where elephants are trained.

Finally, on July 15, the elephant was captured near Palamaner, not far from where it lost its herd.

The whole operation cost around Rs 5 lakh.

The elephant was transported to Musalimadugu Elephant Camp, where it will remain under veterinary observation and a behavioural assessment will be carried out.

Deputy Chief Minister and the Minister for Forests and Environment, K Pawan Kalyan, praised the operation and commended the Forest department for balancing public safety with wildlife conservation.

ORIGINAL PETITIONER, A BREAST CANCER PATIENT, DIED DURING PENDENCY OF PROCEEDINGS

SC takes cognizance of delay in cases involving access to life-saving drugs

Directs Kerala High Court to ensure matter is disposed of expeditiously

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 17

THE SUPREME Court on Friday took suo motu cognisance of delays in cases involving access to life-saving drugs after a pending Kerala HC matter over a breast cancer drug came to its notice.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, hearing the case 'In Re: Access to Life Saving Medicines and Judicial Expediency in Article 21 Matters', referred to the Kerala HC proceedings on Ribociclib, a patented medicine used in the treatment of HR-positive, HER2-negative breast cancer, which had been listed 57 times without reaching a conclusion.

The court said it will issue notice in the case. It also directed the Kerala HC to take up its pending suo motu proceedings at the earliest. It noted that once the HC decodes the matter and issues directions, those may be followed on a pan-India basis.

The case pertains to bringing down Ribociclib's price through domestic manufacture, a request the Centre rejected on the grounds that breast cancer did not meet the threshold of national urgency.

The original petitioner, a breast cancer patient, died during the pendency of the proceedings.

The HC then expanded the scope of the matter and converted it into a suo motu PIL concerning the pricing and accessibility of life-saving medicines.

The SC's intervention follows a July 10 representation to the Chief Justice of the Kerala HC, with copies to the President and the CJI, from Jyotsna Singh and K M Gopakumar, co-convenors of the Working Group on Access to Medicines and Treatment. The letter sought urgent administrative intervention to fast-track the case, noting that pleadings had long concluded even as the matter kept coming up without a final hearing.

The representation stated that Ribociclib costs Rs 78,468 per month and remains under patent protection. It said the original petition sought a government-use licence under the Patents Act to facilitate the manufacture of a lower-cost version of the medicine.

The group said that "the untimely demise of the petitioner in this matter highlights the devastating human cost of judicial delays in cases involving access to lifesaving drugs".

On July 15, the Kerala HC, in the suo motu PIL titled 'In Re Exorbitant Pricing of Life Saving Patented Medicines', sought expert opinions from the National Cancer Institute, Chittaranjan National Cancer Institute, Regional Cancer Centre, Thiruvananthapuram and the Drugs Controller General of India on whether Palbociclib, a less expensive medicine available in India, could serve as an alternative to Ribociclib and Abemaciclib.

With drug body's clearance, Wegovy is first GLP-1 for adults with fatty liver

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 17

THE CENTRAL Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) has given its nod for the use of Novo Nordis's Wegovy (semaglutide 2.4 mg) for the treatment of fatty liver disease, now called MASH (Metabolic Dysfunction-Associated Steatohepatitis).

MASH is a serious, progressive form of fatty liver disease that can lead to chronic inflammation and liver damage. This is the first time an injectable GLP-1 therapy has been approved for such use in India other than obesity. GLP-1 drugs mimic a natural gut hormone that regulates blood sugar, reduces appetite, and slows digestion.

The approval came after Wegovy cleared the ESSENCE trial, in which the drug resolved steatohepatitis among 63% of patients tested and reduced liver fibrosis in 37% of patients.

Semaglutide was found to directly reduce liver fat, inflammation, and scarring. For treatment, a shot of 2.4 mg can be administered.

The development is significant, as two in three Indians report fatty liver disease. MASH is a result of excess fat buildup in the liver, causing chronic inflammation and liver damage. It is a silent disease and symptoms don't appear until the disease has progressed to an advanced stage. Wegovy can work in adults with moderate to advanced liver fibrosis - stages F2 to F3 - along with a reduced calorie diet and increased physical activity.

Vikrant Shrotriya, MD, Novo Nordisk India, said, "The burden of MASH continues to rise in India, but treatment options are still limited. People with MASH face a higher risk of serious liver complications and heart-related diseases. That is why we need treatment options that can address these connected health risks. This approval will also help address obesity and related heart and metabolic diseases."

Gujarat ATS arrests five more with Jaish links; 13 held so far

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, July 17

THE GUJARAT Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) has arrested five men allegedly linked to Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), nearly two weeks after it arrested eight others for their association with the terror outfit, the agency said on Friday.

Out of the five men, four are from Siddhpur in Patan district. This takes the total arrests from the town to eight. The fifth suspect is from Banaskantha.

All five face charges of trying to carry out "test explosions" on at least eight occasions over the last three years.

Police identified the suspects from Siddhpur as Bilal Abid Shera, 24; Mohammad Ayyub Kadiwala, 22; Mohammad Ayyub Sunsara alias Mohammad Khali, 20 and Mohammad Hasan Hanif Kardiya alias Hasan Haiderpuri, 20. Shafi Raees Mukhi alias Shafi Chhapi, 21, is from Vadgam, Banaskantha.

The ATS said that the suspects had procured raw ingredients required for making gunpowder "through online shopping platforms and local markets."

They had studied different methods of carrying bomb blasts, it said. Materials used for the preparation of an (improvised explosive device) IED were recovered from one Mohammad Amin Shera, who was arrested earlier, for examination during the investigation, the agency said.

> ***The ATS said that the suspects had procured raw materials for making gunpowder 'through online shopping platforms and local markets'***

The ATS alleged that Bilal Abid Shera gave a pen drive to Amin Shera that had "jihadi speeches, videos, and jihadi books of Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorist Masood Azhar, which were subsequently printed from various locations".

On July 2, a case was registered against eight men at the Anti-Terrorist Squad police station on charges of terror financing, conspiracy, membership in a terrorist organisation, supporting a terror organisation, etc under the UAPA and conspiracy charges.

The Anti-Terrorist Squad said it recovered a JeM flag, a copy of books written by JeM founder Masood Azhar, a copy of a letter addressed to Azhar, and Rs 1.30 lakh in cash, suspected to be funds for terrorist activities, from the first group of accused.

EQUIPPED WITH HEAT, FLAME DETECTORS

PM flags off India's first hydrogen train: 2-hour Jind-Sonipat travel, 14 halts and zero emission

With 10 coaches, it can carry maximum of 2,600 passengers; 2 round trips a day

Dheeraj Mishra
Jind, July 17

INDIA JOINED a select group of nations on Friday as Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off the country's first hydrogen-powered train connecting Jind and Sonipat in Haryana — a significant achievement for the Indian Railways in the use of zero emission, clean fuel technology.

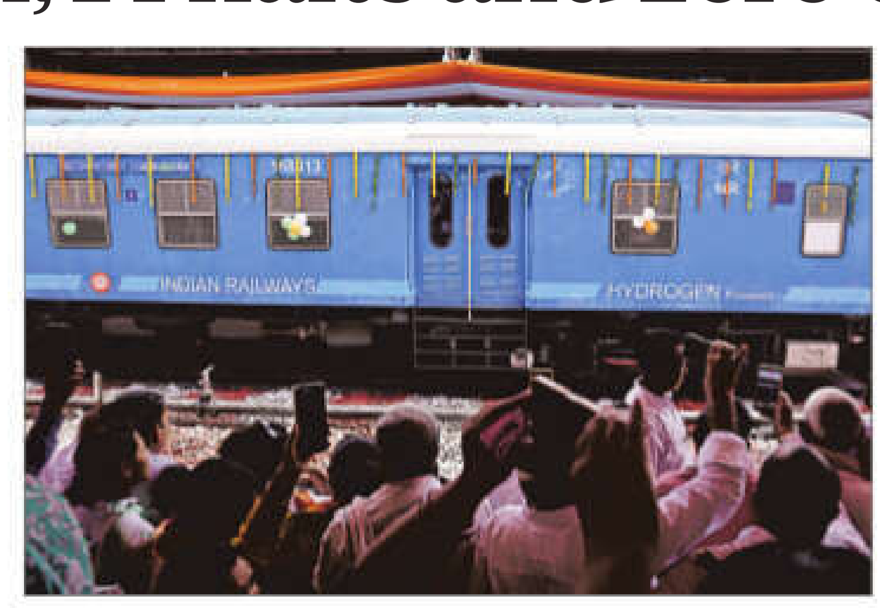
The first hydrogen-powered non-AC passenger train will cover the 89-km Jind-Sonipat railway section in around two hours, running at a maximum operational speed of 75 kmph. The journey includes halts at 14 stations. The Northern Railway is expected to soon announce the date for the commencement of commercial operations.

After flagging off the train from Jind, Modi said, "Even today, we read that India's first train ran between Bombay — now Mumbai — and Thane [in 1853]. Similarly, whenever hydrogen trains are mentioned in the future, the names of Jind, Sonipat and Haryana will inevitably be mentioned."

"If we look at the history of railways, the 19th century was defined by steam engines. The 20th century was characterized by diesel and electric trains, and now, the 21st century belongs to hydrogen-powered trains. Today, Indian Railways has taken a major step forward with this 21st century technology," said Modi.

The train was essentially created by replacing the diesel engines on old diesel electric multiple unit (DEMU) rakes with a zero-emission hydrogen-electric propulsion system. The train will make two round trips a day, covering 356 km and consuming around 300 kg of hydrogen. For refuelling, a 3,000-kg hydrogen capacity storage plant has been developed in Jind.

The Prime Minister said there are immense possibilities of expansion. "We will continue researching how to reduce costs, how to increase efficiency, and step by step, after thorough investigation, we will keep moving forward. Hydrogen trains have only recently come into existence in the world only around 7-8 years ago. Currently, only three or four countries in the world have the capability to run hydrogen trains. And even in those countries, hydrogen trains are still in their early stages," he said.



During the flag-off ceremony of India's first hydrogen-powered train in Jind on Friday. REUTERS

With 3200 horsepower (HP), the 10-coach train — eight passenger and two driving power cars — can carry a maximum of 2,600 passengers. It is equipped with 15 hydrogen leak detectors, seven heat detectors and three flame detectors.

"Not only the most powerful, India's hydrogen train is also the longest. In other countries, hydrogen trains run with three or four coaches. But India, in its very first attempt, has run a 10-coach hydrogen train," the PM said. Chandrakant Kumar, the train's additional loco pilot, said he underwent training in Shakurbasti in Delhi and Integral Coach Factory in Chennai, but added that "there is not much of a difference between driving the hydrogen train and DEMU train".

"Since hydrogen is very flammable, the safety standards in the train are very high. Leak detectors have been installed in the train and the system will shut down automatically in case of such an incident," said Kumar.

"There is 440 kg of hydrogen at a 350 bar pressure on the train — 220 kg in each driving power car — from where the fuel cell will take the hydrogen to produce electrical energy. It will take around four hours to refill the hydrogen cylinders on board from the plant. There are eight fans and six CCTVs in each driving power car. The hydrogen leak detectors and flame detectors are installed at the plants as well."

Nitin Parikh, a train manager on board, said the primary job is to run the train safely and on time. "However, it is great that we have accepted the new and clean technology for Railways. It will help in cutting down the emission significantly. In this train, the emission is only the water vapour. This is not the main line, but the branch line and number of passengers are higher."

On board the country's first hydrogen train were students of Nav Vidya Senior Secondary School, Jind. "It is a beautiful train. I am a Class 9 student and I have learnt how electrolysis splits water into hydrogen and oxygen. I have not travelled very far by train yet. I want to travel to Delhi by train," said Alisha, as the train chugged off from Jind.

Other projects

Modi also inaugurated the Haryana section of the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway (158 km), the Jind-Gohana National Highway (40.60 km), Ambala-Kala Amb four-lane highway (33.81 km) and Sikh museum in Kurukshetra. The PM laid the foundation stone and inaugurated various projects worth around Rs 14,700 crore in Jind.

Referring to the West Asia conflict, he said that due to 99% electrification of Railways, trains ran continuously despite the oil crisis in the wake of the Strait of Hormuz situation.

A semiconductor vision beyond the shop floor

THE UNION Cabinet's approval of the second phase of the India Semiconductor Mission marks a shift from creating semiconductor factories to building an innovation landscape in this cutting-edge sector. Having laid the foundations for semiconductor manufacturing, India is now attempting something more ambitious: Integrating chip design, equipment, materials, intellectual property and advanced research into a coherent industrial strategy. A key objective of the Rs 1,27,500 crore outlay announced earlier this week is to facilitate semiconductor design. This is where much of the industry's value is created. Countries without cutting-edge fabrication plants can occupy pivotal positions in global supply chains through chip architecture, verification, software and intellectual property. The policy is, therefore, prudent in reducing fiscal support for fabrication units and redirecting it to companies that make the raw materials, speciality chemicals and industrial gases needed to produce chips. Subsidies of up to 75 per cent on chip design underline the premium it places on R&D.

India's immediate goal of an ecosystem capable of manufacturing mature node chips — 28 nm or larger — might appear modest by the standards of market leaders such as South Korea, Taiwan and China, which have gained proficiency in sub-10 nm chip making. However, mature node chips account for around 70 per cent of global semiconductor demand. Electronics, smartphones, power grids and medical devices do not require very small chips. The policy is, therefore, right on India's comparative advantages. That said, the country must not lose sight of developments in the fast-moving sector. The global chip market has repeatedly been disrupted in the last five years. If the Covid pandemic exposed deficiencies in supply chains, tech rivalries continue to make the semiconductor value chain precarious. Every major power — the US, China, South Korea, Taiwan, the Netherlands, Japan — uses its semiconductor capabilities as strategic leverage. That's why India's goal to develop 7nm and 2nm chips in the next five years is significant, even though it's largely aspirational today.

Building semiconductor capabilities will require much more than financial incentives. Even momentary power interruptions can destroy production batches, logistics must function with clockwork precision, environmental clearances must be rigorous but also predictable, and skilled technicians must be available in large numbers. Indian engineers work on semiconductor design for some of the world's leading firms, and global outfits have established design centres in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Noida. The challenge is to translate this advantage into world-class manufacturing capacity through a judicious mix of market forces and state support. Like its counterparts in Taiwan, South Korea and the US, the Indian government will have to be an enabler and build linkages between academia and industry.

Sleepless nights, a public health challenge

RISING TEMPERATURES are keeping Indians up at night. A recent study by a US-based climate advocacy group, which assessed the loss of sleeping hours in over 1,300 cities across the world, has found that the average person has lost nearly 56 hours of sleep annually between 2020 and 2025 due to unusually high night-time temperatures. At least 10 per cent of this sleep loss is directly attributable to climate change. In some of India's largest cities, people are losing significantly more sleep than the global average, from 93 hours in Chennai to 84 hours in Mumbai and 67 hours in Delhi. As summers get longer, hotter and more humid, these findings should be seen as a warning. Sleep is often treated as an individual problem to be fixed with better lifestyle choices. But when the environment makes rest difficult, sleep becomes a public health challenge.

Heat is just one of the factors that is causing Indians to toss and turn in their beds. A review of literature on sleep disorders, published last year in the *Indian Journal of Public Health*, found a widespread prevalence of sleep disorders across India. Sleep loss/deprivation connected to rapidly changing lifestyles, excessive screen time, social-media addiction, erratic eating habits and shift-based work schedules compound the challenges. Sleep is essential for cellular repair, immune function and regulating inflammation. Even modest reductions in sleep, when repeated over weeks or months, can have lasting effects, with chronic sleep deprivation being associated with hypertension, diabetes, heart disease, obesity and cognitive impairment, while also reducing workplace productivity and increasing the risk of accidents.

India needs to recognise healthy sleep as an essential pillar of public health. Heat action plans should account not only for daytime exposure but also for dangerously warm nights, particularly in dense urban settlements where the heat island effect is strongest. Urban planning, affordable cooling solutions and better housing design all have a role. Equally important is integrating sleep health into public health campaigns. As India deals with non-communicable diseases, protecting the country's sleep may prove to be an important investment in its long-term health.

Ten lessons from 10 years in the Land of the Rising Sun

PEMA KHANDU

ON JULY 17, 2016, I took oath as the Chief Minister of Arunachal Pradesh. As I complete a decade in office, I find myself reflecting not on milestones alone, but on the enduring lessons that I have imbibed while serving this land and its remarkable people. There are 10 that stand out.

The first lesson is that leadership is service, or it is nothing at all. I have had the rare privilege of observing governance at close quarters under Prime Minister Narendra Modi*ji*. What I have learnt from him is not merely his style of administration, but a way of thinking: That every decision must be rooted in *seva*. When the PM visits the Northeast more often than all his predecessors combined, it reflects a conviction that leadership begins by paying attention to those who have long remained at the margins.

The second lesson came from my party. The BJP gave me a simple yet profound philosophy of governance: *Antyodaya*, the commitment to serve the last person. In Arunachal Pradesh, where the last household may be a seven-day trek from the nearest road, *antyodaya* is a governing principle. That is why Arunachal became the first state in the Northeast to achieve 100 per cent Har Ghar Jal coverage.

The third lesson is that national security admits no compromise. Arunachal Pradesh has over 1,000 km of international borders. Every road we construct, every frontier village we strengthen, every child we educate in these regions contributes to India's security. Our border villages are not India's last villages; they are our first.

The fourth lesson required us to overcome an old and deeply held fear: Connectivity is a strength, not a vulnerability. For decades, development in Arunachal was constrained by the belief that better roads might one day benefit an adversary. Our government chose to reverse that mindset. It took 75 years for Itanagar to get an airport; today, Donyi Polo Airport connects us to Delhi in just three hours. The Sela Tunnel, the Trans-Arunachal Highway and the Frontier Highway are pathways to opportunity.

The fifth lesson is that lasting prosperity is the only sustainable answer to poverty. Over the past decade, Arunachal's GSDP has grown two-and-a-half times, while our own revenues have increased fivefold. Today, hydropower projects totalling about 19,000 MW are under development. Our future lies in entrepreneurship, sustainable tourism and the responsible use of our natural resources. The Prime Minister has described the eight northeastern states as India's Ashtalakshmi, the eight forms of prosperity.

The sixth lesson is that environmental stewardship is not an obstacle to development; it is the very foundation of it. With nearly 80 per cent forest cover, Arunachal Pradesh is one of the world's great natural carbon sinks. Our Pakke Declaration 2047, adopted by the cabinet inside a tiger reserve, a first for any Indian state, commits us to building a climate-resilient economy.

The seventh lesson is that institutions outlast individuals. I assumed office at a time when frequent political instability had disrupted continuity and stability in governance. The past decade has therefore been devoted to building systems that are transparent, stable and accountable.. That stability is perhaps the most enduring accomplishment of these 10 years.

The eighth lesson is that trust can only be earned through transparency. We established the Staff Selection Board through legislation to eliminate favouritism in recruitment, and we rebuilt the Public Service Commission after past irregularities. Zero tolerance towards corruption is becoming part of our administrative culture.

The ninth lesson is that the government must reflect the aspirations of its people. Through initiatives such as Sarkar Aapke Dwar and cabinet meetings held across district headquarters, we have sought to bring governance closer to citizens, right at their doorsteps. Democracy acquires greater meaning when people can see their own hopes and aspirations reflected in public policy.

The 10th and perhaps most important lesson is this: Invest in the young. Our reforms in health and education, our efforts to build high-quality schools and medical colleges and our investments in sports are not expenditures; they are our most valuable investments. A child growing up in Tawang or Tirap deserves the same opportunities and the same horizon as a child in Delhi or Bengaluru.

Ten years ago, I inherited a state seeking stability. Today, I have the privilege of serving a state defined by confidence and aspiration. As India advances towards the goal of Viksit Bharat, Arunachal Pradesh will continue to demonstrate that the nation's frontiers are not its periphery; they are where its future is being written first.

For decades, development in Arunachal was constrained by the belief that better roads might one day benefit an adversary. Our government chose to reverse that mindset

The writer is Chief Minister of Arunachal Pradesh

The bittersweet realities of the India-UK FTA

ANISREE SURESH

DESPITE THE turbulence of recent leadership transitions in London and last-minute friction over steel protectionism, India and the UK have finally put their FTA into effect as of July 15. India was able to carve out an 85 per cent exemption for its baseline exports at the eleventh hour, just days ahead of the UK's new steel trade measures hitting on July 1. However, the deal coexists with a bittersweet reality that the market access and export opportunities of modern FTAs remain massive, yet the trade deals have become hyper-transactional, defensive, and limited. While an 85 per cent volume exemption for India's existing steel trade with the UK applies, the simultaneous rollout of the EU's compressed steel import limits from July 1 undermines the UK's potential to serve as a tariff-free safe haven for Indian steel exports squeezed out of Europe.

The sweet part of the deal is that India secured immediate zero-duty market access across 99 per cent of its tariff lines. Under the initial agreement, concluded in 2025, the steel sector was slated to move towards zero-duty access to India's $893 million steel trade. However, the recent pivot in the UK's steel trade measures rewrites the rules for market access. By cutting global tariff-free import caps by 51 per cent and doubling the over-quota penalty to a 50 per cent tariff, the UK effectively built a tariff wall around its borders on steel. Given that roughly $484 million of India's steel exports consists of semi-finished slabs, raw inputs, and speciality alloy wires that British steelworks lack the capacity to manufacture, the UK removed 11 specific commodity codes from the safeguard scope, allowing such exports from India without any restrictions.

However, the remaining 15 per cent across 188 tariff lines, such as standard Category 1 hot-rolled sheets, are now locked behind a rigid Country-Specific Quota (CSQ) of just 33,456 tonnes per year. If Indian exporters exhaust their dedicated CSQ for the quarter, they will have to compete in a shared global reserve pool to secure additional shipments at zero duty before the 50 per cent penalty tariff triggers.

While it's good news that 85 per cent of India's baseline trade is unaffected under this framework, it becomes a challenge when read alongside the EU's simultaneous cap from July 1, which limits total global steel imports to 18.3 million tonnes. Under the new EU regulation, the out-of-quota customs duty, which currently stands at 25 per cent, has been increased to 50 per cent. Under the EU country-specific quota announcement, there is a 33 per cent reduction in quota for India's Hot Rolled Coil (Category 1) steel exports to Europe, which might be forced to seek alternative destinations. The India-UK FTA is also now unable to provide a safe haven for the additional steel that might be forced to reroute. Indian steel exporters have already been facing a global export squeeze. Taken together, the India-UK FTA was able to protect the baseline trade volume, but might not be enough to cushion the blow when the world's largest consumer blocs turn inward to insulate their domestic industrial bases.

Modern FTAs no longer guarantee unfettered, comprehensive market access; instead, they are highly transactional and limited in scope. India must aggressively recalibrate its geopolitical and economic leverage to secure exemptions and reliable market access to thrive in the new world order.

Modern FTAs no longer guarantee unfettered, comprehensive market access; instead, they are highly transactional and limited in scope

The writer is a research associate at Takshashila Institution

The delimitation debate is a fight over the wrong number

PRAVEEN CHAKRAVARTY

ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

PARLIAMENT'S FIRST power is the power of the purse: Its central task is to scrutinise how money is collected and where it goes. Money is raised from taxes and logically, richer states contribute more. It is then spent on people's welfare and justifiably, poorer states receive more.

Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Telangana contribute roughly 20 per cent of all taxes (direct plus indirect) while Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh contribute 6 per cent. Clearly, the three richer southern states account for significantly higher contributions to the Union government's tax kitty. Five years ago, the three southern states contributed 18 per cent to the nation's taxes while the latter group of states accounted for 7 per cent. So, the share of the southern states in India's tax revenues is only rising while that of the latter is declining.

At the same time, these three southern states account for 13 per cent of the population while the three northern states account for 33 per cent. Ten years ago, the three southern states had 14 per cent of India's population and the northern states 32 per cent. Ten years from now, only 12 per cent of the population will be from these southern states and 34 per cent from the latter group of northern states. Evidently, the share of population of southern states is only decreasing while that of the latter is increasing. So, in India, states' share of revenues and population seem to go in opposite directions.

Poorer states need greater funds and are also more populous with higher birth rates. Richer states contribute more money and tend to be less populous with falling birth rates. If the financial oversight function of Parliament includes both collecting and spending money, then isn't it logical to expect representation for states proportionate to their contribution to tax collections as well as to their spending needs? Put simply, why is a state's share of contribution to the Union tax kitty not a factor in determining its share of representation in Parliament, while only its share of population is counted as a factor? Especially when the share of contribution and population are inversely related.

The idea of a population-based representative democracy with a decadal census to measure the size of population and redraw constituencies was right at a time of rampant slavery and agrarian economies in 1787, when James Madison drafted it in the US Constitution. Back then, an elected representative physically carried the concerns of a fixed body of people, and there were natural limits to how many one person could reach, canvass and answer to. Roughly equal numbers of people per seat were a fair proxy for roughly equal access and equal voice.

But what is so sacrosanct about it being the sole determinant of share of representation today? In 2026, a Member of Parliament who wants to reach her voters does not walk the district. She sends a message, and it lands with 100,000 people or a million for the same effort and the same cost. The point is deliberately provocative: Population is no longer a good measure of the burden of representation, because technology has dissolved that burden.

"Equal population per seat" bundles two different claims. One is practical: A representative can only serve so many, so seats should be sized to a manageable number. The other is moral: Every citizen is equal, so every vote should carry equal weight. Technology has hollowed out the first claim. It has not touched the second. No one can argue that an Indian in Kanpur deserves less voice than an Indian in Coimbatore.

What is so sacrosanct about it being the sole determinant of share of representation today? In 2026, a Member of Parliament who wants to reach her voters does not walk the district. She sends a message

This is not a plea to let rich states buy votes, nor to price a citizen's franchise by her tax receipt. Every individual's vote stays exactly equal. But delimitation is not about the individual vote. It is about the collective weight of a state in the national legislature — and in a federation, that cannot be settled by headcount alone. So, the question is not whether every citizen should count equally — of course they should — but whether a state's collective leverage in Parliament should track only its population or be more holistic.

Parliament's job is to decide how the Union's money is raised and spent. States that supply a larger share of that money must be given their due share of voice in Parliament. But this does not mean money should be the only measure. This is of course not a call to hark back to the days of voting rights only for taxpayers. It is a call for the Delimitation Commission to come to terms with the realities of 21st-century Indian federalism and arrive at a more comprehensive formula for share in Parliament just as the Finance Commission does for share in taxes.

The current formula of a population-only based delimitation exercise only elicits warped and regressive ideas such as Chandrababu Naidu and M K Stalin urging families in their states to have more children and coming up with "PLI" schemes for "baby production". Not out of any theory of human flourishing, but just to defend seats in a future delimitation and prevent migrant labour from other states.

Change the denominator and the whole conversation changes with it. No chief minister has to treat childbirth as a seat-protection strategy. If share of taxes is also factored in for share in Parliament, then the other vexatious issue of inter-state migration will become less political. After all, migrant labour contributes to the economy and taxes of the state. There is already an irony in the arithmetic: Much of the tax revenue Karnataka and Tamil Nadu remit is generated by workers who migrated from the very states now poised to gain seats, and who are still counted in the populations they left.

And so, the argument between states shifts from babies and migrants to development and finance, which is the argument a serious federation ought to be having in the first place.

The delimitation fight is a fight over the wrong number — which census year to use? The real question is: Should population be the sole determinant of parliamentary representation? The denominator should be some combination of population and economic contribution that reflects not just how many people a state has, but how much their state contributes to the national whole.

The writer is a Member of Parliament, chairman of All India Professionals' Congress, and visiting professor, Ashoka University

A power verdict with consequences beyond Railways

RAKESH KACKER AND CHITRAKSHI JAIN

A DIVISION BENCH of the Supreme Court recently dismissed a batch of appeals involving the Indian Railways. The judgment has implications for public and private entities seeking the status of a deemed distribution licensee under the Electricity Act. The APTEL judgment from which the appeals arose had rejected the claim of the Indian Railways to be treated as a deemed distribution licensee, a view that has been upheld by the SC.

The Court was tasked with deciding first whether the Indian Railways qualifies as a deemed distribution licensee. It held that a distribution licensee must not only operate and maintain a distribution system, but it is also required to supply electricity to consumers. Indian Railways does not pass this test unambiguously, for it "operates a closed network for meeting operational requirements of the railways system".

Next, the SC had to decide if the Railways fell within the ambit of "Appropriate Government" under the third proviso to Section 14, which confers deemed licensee status and exempts the entity from obtaining a licence. The Railways had assumed that, as an agency of the Union government, it was entitled to a deemed licence. The Court held that the Railways could not be treated as a deemed licensee because it only bought electricity for self-consumption. It distinguished the Railways from the Military Engineering Services, which supply electricity to residents for cantonments, clarifying that a government entity must perform the function of distribution to different consumers to qualify as a deemed licensee under the third proviso to Section 14. The SC also held that, given that the Railways buys electricity for its own use, like any other consumer, it would have to pay the associated cross-subsidy surcharge and the additional surcharge.

The ruling is significant for several reasons. The Railways will have to compensate the discoms for the surcharges, resulting in a steep bill that will include backdated dues from different states. The decision has implications for other entities seeking deemed-licensee status. In April, the Andhra Pradesh government published a policy framework to promote data centres — new data centres with a minimum connected load of 300 MW could qualify as deemed licensees. The Centre has, in the past, given similar benefits to SEZ developers. The judgment makes it considerably harder for data centres to rely on deemed licence status. Entities may instead have to obtain a regular distribution licence under the Act and satisfy the accompanying regulatory obligations, including demonstrating that they intend to supply electricity to consumers rather than merely consume it themselves.

The Railways will have to compensate the discoms for the surcharges, incurring a steep bill. The decision has implications for other entities who seek the status of deemed licensees

Uttar Pradesh has a similar policy. In 2023, UPERC granted a distribution licence to NIDP Developers (a data centre developer) under the sixth proviso to Section 14, which allows multiple distribution licensees to operate in the same area. The SC judgment has limited the ability of the Union and state governments and regulators to grant deemed licensee status. It has called into question the order of the Commerce Ministry dated March 3, 2010, which enabled SEZ developers to get a deemed licence. It remains to be seen if the Centre will attempt an amendment of the Electricity Act to restore these powers to governments and regulators.

Kacker is retired secretary, Government of India and member, Advisory Board at TrustBridge Rule of Law Foundation. Jain is a researcher at TrustBridge Rule of Law Foundation

'JAN VISHWAS SIDDHANT' SEEKS TO CREATE A TRUST-BASED REGULATORY ENVIRONMENT

NITI seeks tech firms' views on content blocking regime

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 17

AS PART of its broad deregulation push, government think tank NITI Aayog has turned its eye at India's expansive tech laws framework — which falls under the domain of the IT Ministry — and has asked major tech companies and start-ups if the country's current online content blocking requirements and transparency timelines are "feasible."

It has sought their views on how current legislation can be simplified, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Aayog sought views on a wide range of regulatory issues, covering laws impacting social media companies and other online intermediaries, cybersecurity, data protection, and online gaming, among others.

Executives of technology industry bodies, who represent several Big Tech companies, took part in the meeting held on June 25.

A presentation including questions was shown to the stakeholders during the meeting. In the section covering platform governance, the NITI Aayog asked: "Are current takedown, grievance, and transparency timelines operationally feasible across different categories and sizes of intermediaries?" Another question said: "Which intermediary due diligence obligations impose the highest recurring compliance burden, and what specific operational simplifications would be most impactful?"

Representatives of industry groupings such as Nasscom, Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI), and Broadband India Forum (BIF), among others, are learnt to have taken part in the meeting. Many of these groups represent major American tech companies such as Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube.

Tech companies, through these industry groupings, are expected to respond along likely lines, and pushback against India's shortened takedown timelines, as they have done on several occasions, publicly and privately. The NITI Aayog is expected to go through the industry's responses and then send a detailed note to the IT Ministry for its comments and feedback on the Aayog's recommendations. The IT Ministry may or may not agree with the Aayog's recommendations.

Queries sent to the NITI Aayog and IT Ministry did not elicit a response till the publication of this news.

These discussions are happening under the NITI Aayog's new 'Jan Vishwas Siddhant' initiative, an effort at creating a trust-based regulatory environment, under which the government think tank is collecting inputs from various sectors on deregulation and rationalisation of existing laws.

Speaking at the CII Annual Business Summit 2026 earlier this year, NITI Aayog member Rajiv Gauba said that the move was aimed at clearing the system's "regulatory cholesterol".

The questions around content takedowns also assume significance as India has stepped up its content blocking ecosystem in recent years, with over 24,000 orders issued in 2025, up from the over 12,000 orders it had issued in 2024, *The Indian Express* had earlier reported.

In February, the IT Ministry notified amendments to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021. One of the changes it has implemented is that social media platforms must now remove problematic content within two-three hours as opposed to 24-36 hours before. Industry executives had earlier said that the new timeline is the shortest takedown window prescribed by any government in the world.

Raising concerns over the shortened takedown timelines, social media giant Meta, which operates platforms like Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, had said at the time that the norms might be "challenging" to comply with from an operational standpoint.

Rob Sherman, Meta's vice president policy and deputy chief privacy officer, said in February that when social media companies receive takedown notices from the government, there is a certain time it takes for them to investigate and validate the flagged content, and three hours might not be enough time for that.

"Whenever we get the request from the government (to take down content), we will have to look into it, we will have to investigate it and validate it ourselves. And so that's just something that takes some amount of time, particularly if there's something that we need to look into. That's often not possible to turn around in three hours," he had added.

The Indian Express had earlier also reported that the Centre was exploring allowing the ministries of Home Affairs, External Affairs, Defence, and Information and Broadcasting to issue content blocking orders to social media platforms under Section 69 (A) of the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000, a power currently available to the IT Ministry. However, the move is currently stalled, it is understood.

• EASING THE REGULATIONS?

DISCUSSIONS ARE happening under the NITI Aayog's new 'Jan Vishwas Siddhant' initiative, an initiative to create a trust-based regulatory environment

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Investment Friendliness Index: Gujarat, Maha, TN on top

Pratyush Deep & Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 17

GUJARAT, MAHARASHTRA, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Goa have emerged as top-performing states in NITI Aayog's new Investment Friendliness Index 2026, which ranks states based on quality of infrastructure, business climate, government policy and regulatory ease among other parameters seen as key to attracting investment.

"Our investment rate is around 25%. If you look at China, when it was growing fast, it was investing almost double that amount. We are using our capital very efficiently. But if you look at their investment rate and growth rate, you get the incremental capital-output ratio. China's incremental capital output ratio is much higher. The index is not a ranking exercise; it is to tell the states that there are indicators where you are doing well and parameters where you can do better," Ashok Lahiri, Vice Chairman, NITI Aayog, said at a press briefing.

The index covers all 28 states and eight union territories (UTs) and evaluates what makes a state attractive for investors, as well as the challenges investors face. The highest weight of 25% is assigned to infrastructure, followed by business climate, resources, government policy, regulatory ease, financial health, institutional environment and environmental resilience. The index categorises Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Chandigarh, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka among other states as "frontrunners".

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI moves closer to polymer notes, subsidiary floats tender

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 17

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) is set to trial polymer currency notes, with the Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran Private Limited (BRBNMPL) on Friday floating a global tender for polymer sheets that will be used to print currency notes at its own presses and that of Security Printing and Minting Corporation of India (SPMCIL).

While BRBNMPL is a wholly-owned subsidiary of the RBI, SPMCIL is a public sector undertaking. The former designs, manufactures, and supplies banknotes. SPMCIL prints them too along with stamp papers, stamps, and other documents such as passports that require security features. The BRBNMPL tender calls for bids for 68,000 reams — one ream comprises 500 sheets — of so-called Biaxially Oriented Polypropylene-based Opacified Polymer Substrate with security features to print the banknotes. The last date to submit bids is August 18.

The tender document said 34,000 reams will be used in the printing of one denomination of notes. As such, the trial will comprise two denominations of notes.

The RBI did not respond to an e-mail seeking comments on the details of the trial.

"The indicative requirement in this EOI is meant for immediate requirement. Once our field trials are successful, we intend to go for procurement of larger quantity of substrate across different denominations and the same is likely to be shared in the upcoming RFP/Final tender or in future tenders which shall follow this EOI (Expression of Interest)," the tender document said.

It added that bidders must ensure that their operations in Pakistan or China, if any, must be "suitably firewalled" from those in India. No raw materials used to make the India-specific polymer sheets should be procured from China or Pakistan.

Further, a declaration will have to be made that no employee of the bidder who has previously worked or been posted in Pakistan or China, in any capacity, will be engaged for the current procurement process. Pakistani and Chinese nationals or persons of Pakistani or Chinese origin are not to be engaged by bidders for the project. The tender comes after RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra had said at the post-monetary policy press conference on June 5 that a proposal on polymer notes was "currently under consideration", although no decision had been taken.

"We are examining the pros and cons of it and whether, you know, it will be worthwhile to do it. It is still at a preliminary stage," Malhotra had said.

First issued by Australia in 1988, polymer banknotes are now used in more than 50 countries and are widely considered to be far superior to paper notes.

A polymer note can last anywhere between two to six times longer than a paper note, which means it has a lower environmental impact. A longer life means fewer polymer notes need to be manufactured and distributed.

According to British firm De La Rue, which supplies notes to more than half of all central banks, polymer notes are cleaner, wipe clean easily, can be recycled, and more secure as most counterfeit notes are produced on paper.

Counterfeit rates have fallen in countries where currency notes are made of polymer. In 2025-26, the RBI spent Rs 4,875 crore to print currency notes. More than 17,000 crore Indian currency notes – worth Rs 41 lakh crore – were in circulation as on March 31, 2026. Last year, the RBI supplied 2,810 crore pieces of notes. The number of counterfeit notes detected last year rose to 2.3 lakh pieces, up from 2.17 lakh in 2024-25.

• PLASTIC CURRENCY

FIRST ISSUED by Australia in 1988, polymer banknotes are now used in over 50 countries and are widely considered far superior to paper notes

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BRITISH FIRM De La Rue, which supplies notes to more than half of all central banks, says that polymer notes are cleaner, wipe clean easily, can be recycled, and more secure as most counterfeit notes are produced on paper

SEBI cautions firms against rising 'Boss Scam'

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 17

THE SECURITIES and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has cautioned regulated entities and listed companies against a rapidly emerging cyber fraud known as the 'Boss Scam', in which fraudsters impersonate CEO or managing director to carry out the crime.

Acting on inputs from the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), the market regulator has urged organisations to strengthen internal verification procedures as fraudsters increasingly exploit artificial intelligence, deepfake technology and malicious software to deceive finance officials into transferring funds.

In a press statement issued on Friday, SEBI said cybercriminals are targeting chief executive officers, managing directors and other senior officials by impersonating them through email, WhatsApp, Microsoft Teams and other social media platforms.

The fraudsters send convincing messages or place fake calls to employees, particularly those handling financial transactions, instructing them to make urgent payments to bank accounts controlled by criminals. According to SEBI, the scam typically follows two distinct methods. In the first, fraudsters use advanced deepfake technology, including AI-generated voice cloning and manipulated video calls, to convincingly imitate senior executives.

They may also create fake social media groups or messaging accounts that appear to belong to company leadership. Employees receiving such communications are often pressured into executing immediate fund transfers, it said. The second method involves the distribution of malicious compressed (.zip) files containing executable (.exe) and Dynamic Link Library (.dll) files. These files, once downloaded and opened on Windows computers, install malware capable of compromising the victim's device.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

New core industries index to have iron ore

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 17

THE COMMERCE ministry will release the updated Index of Core Industries (ICI) next week, with the number of core industries set to increase to nine following the inclusion of iron ore to the existing eight: coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilisers, steel, cement, and electricity.

"In view of the extensive use of iron ore in industrial production and its significant contribution to industrial development, iron ore has been included as a core industry in the revised ICI series. Consequently, the number of core industries has increased from eight to nine," the Ministry of Commerce & Industry said in a statement on Friday. As per the latest data, core sector growth in May was at a seven-month low of 0.5%. The revised core sector data — which will be released on Monday for the month of June along with a back-series starting April 2023 — continues the government's overhaul of India's official statistics in a hectic year.

FULL REPORT ON
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HISTORY, ALMOST

25 years of Agra Summit, and what lies ahead for India, Pakistan

Given the historical baggage and a series of betrayals by Pakistan — from Kargil to Kandahar — Vajpayee's decision to invite Musharraf to Agra in July 2001 was a bold one. Twenty-five years after the failed Summit, SHUBHAJIT ROY talks to some of the key officials involved to see what that moment holds for the future of the two warring neighbours

"AB AAGE *kya karna chahiye?* (What should we do next)?" On May 23, 2001, at one of their periodic lunches, Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee asked the question of his Home Minister L K Advani and External Affairs and Defence Minister Jaswant Singh.

The question was in reference to Pakistan. It had been two years since the Kargil War and the main instigator, General Pervez Musharraf, was in power in Pakistan.

As Advani and Jaswant Singh, Vajpayee's long-time colleagues, expressed their support for engagement with Pakistan, a Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) was called the same day. That very evening, an invitation went out to Musharraf.

Two months later, this invitation would result in the Agra Summit that lasted from July 14 to 16, 2001. The Summit marked a fleeting moment when it looked like the two countries would finally begin resolving differences across the negotiating table. But it ended in spectacular fashion, with Musharraf cutting short his visit, followed by one of the lowest points for India-Pakistan relations.

Now, 25 years later, with official engagement between the two countries at a complete halt, except for sporadic Track-II level talks, the Summit holds valuable lessons — on both the possibilities and futility of dialogue when the mistrust runs as deep as it does between the two nations.

The Summit, say those closely involved with the talks and others who watched it from the sidelines, was audacious in its ambition — and that, perhaps, proved to be its undoing. They also say that chances of another meeting of the kind are remote, given the "political risk" involved.

Ajay Bisaria, who was Vajpayee's private secretary at the time of the Agra Summit, and later served as India's High Commissioner to Pakistan, tells *The Indian Express*, "In hindsight, the error at Agra was clearly insufficient preparation. They should have prepped the Summit properly — sent teams back and forth. Instead, the approach was, 'Let's see what the General does'. The failure was implicit in that."

T C A Raghavan, then Director in Jaswant Singh's office who later served as India's envoy to Pakistan (June 2013-December 2015), agrees. "It was a missed opportunity, but it was also an underprepared summit. Not in terms of work put in... a lot of very great detail was gone into. But it was in an echo chamber."

At the same time, says Raghavan, there is no doubting the significance of the Summit. "What strikes me is how big a step it was to invite Musharraf to India, the fact that a step like that could be taken then, in the aftermath of two seismic events in 1999 (the Kargil War and the Kandahar hijacking) is really quite extraordinary," says Raghavan, the author of the book *The People Next Door: The Curious History of India's Relations with Pakistan*.

Vivek Katju, who, as Joint Secretary, MEA, in charge of Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran, was a key official from the Indian side for the Agra Summit, says the talks illustrated the difference between the two leaders. "Prior to and during the Agra Summit, PM Vajpayee showed that he was a true statesman while Musharraf demonstrated all the obsessions of his institution," he tells *The Indian Express*.

Katju, incidentally, played a key role during both the Kargil War and as a negotiator during the December 1999 IC-814 Kandahar hijacking.

The making of a Summit

In his book *Anger Management: The Troubled Diplomatic Relationship Between India and Pakistan*, Bisaria said the mention of talks at the time took even the top officials by surprise.

About the day the invite went out to Musharraf, he wrote, "When the discussion was brought to the Cabinet Committee on Security, a couple of MEA officers, Vivek Katju and Raminder Jassal, waited in my office... Jaswant Singh walked in and informed them of the 'well thought out decision' to invite Pakistan's dictator. 'Good grief,' said Jassal, reflecting the anti-Musharraf mood prevalent in the baffled foreign office... India had, in essence, reversed its decision on not engaging with Pakistan."

Another reason it was seen as a big move by Vajpayee was that his earlier initiative, the Lahore bus yatra of 1999, had ended in the "betrayal" of the Kargil War. With the Kandahar hijacking following soon after in December 1999, the Vajpayee government was emphatic that it would not resume talks unless Pakistan stopped aiding and abetting cross-border terrorism.

The first hints of the BJP veteran's desire for peace had come first in November 2000 when, on the eve of Ramzan, he announced a unilateral six-month ceasefire on counter-insurgency operations in Jammu and Kashmir. On January 1, 2001, Vajpayee wrote about re-engaging with Pakistan in musings penned during a break in Kumarakom, Kerala. The PM's remark to his colleagues in May that year about what they should do next — "*ab aage kya karna chahiye?*" — came just before the six-month ceasefire was to end.

Recalling the conversation in his autobiography *My Country, My Life*, Advani wrote that in response to Vajpayee's question, he had said, "Atalji, why don't you invite the General to come to India for talks? It does not matter if your Lahore initiative failed. It was highly appreciated both at home and abroad. Similarly, your invitation to him will be welcomed as an act of statesmanship."

Advani wrote that the venue initially proposed was Goa, but Vajpayee suggested Agra.

On June 19, came the announcement – India would host Musharraf from July 14 to 16, including a welcome in Delhi, a retreat in Agra, and a visit to Ajmer Sharif.

A series of unilateral confidence-building announcements by India followed: 20 scholarships for Pakistani students at Indian technical institutions; month-long invites to Pakistani poets, academics, writers and artistes; release of Pakistani prisoners; and a reduction in tariffs.

Before leaving for India, Musharraf, till then designated as Chief Executive of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, anointed himself "President". When he landed in Delhi, he was met by then Indian President K R Narayanan at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

Musharraf in Delhi

In Delhi, Musharraf's first halt along with wife Sehba was a visit to Naherwali Gali in Old Delhi on July 14. It was his family home till 1947, and Musharraf was four when they left it for Pakistan. The President next went to Raj Ghat and the Gandhi memorial nearby.

Advani, who met him at Rashtrapati Bhavan the same day, spoke to him about their common alma mater, St Patrick's High School in Karachi, and expressed the wish that people of the two countries with roots on either side should be able to go across the border easily.

At this point, Advani is said to have suggested that underworld don Dawood Ibrahim should be handed over to India. Musharraf's face "turned red", Advani wrote, and he said: "Mr Advani, let me tell you emphatically that Dawood Ibrahim is not in Pakistan." Advani said he then raised the issue of Indians being killed in "Pakistan-sponsored" terrorist attacks, and Musharraf replied by saying that "the core issue is the Kashmir dispute".

This was the first indication of what the General was thinking. Later, it would be on this issue that the talks would collapse.

In Agra, the Pakistani team stayed at the newly-built Oberoi Amarvilas Hotel, while Indians led by Vajpayee camped at Jaypee Palace, which was also the official venue for the talks. Vajpayee was accompanied by his entire CCS — apart from Advani and Jaswant Singh, Finance Minister Yashwant Sinha and Commerce Minister Murasoli Maran. Also present were National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra, India's High Commissioner to Pakistan Vijay Nambiar, Katju in his capacity as Joint Secretary, and Information Minister Sushma Swaraj.

On July 15, as the bilateral meeting with Musharraf started, Vajpayee laid out India's goals in "precise" terms, wrote Advani — a detailed exchange of views, including on J&K and cross-border terrorism, the issue of terrorists taking refuge in gurdwaras in Pakistan, as well as the upkeep of Hindu temples and treatment of Hindu pilgrims in the country.

Indicating how Musharraf was playing to a larger audience, Bisaria recalled in his book that Musharraf launched into an exposition of his plans "to bring grassroots democracy to Pakistan". Bisaria wrote that he raised this with Vajpayee, particularly the irony of Pakistan's dictator explaining democracy to Indian leadership.

Jaswant Singh and Pakistani Foreign Minister Abdul Sattar were to frame a joint statement on July 15. Singh wrote in his book *A Call to Honour* that there was some good-natured banter between them, and after some back and forth over a draft, where both made some changes, they decided to take it to their leaders.

Advani recalled in his book that when they discussed the issue on the evening of the 15th, "I noticed that there was no reference to cross-border terrorism (in the draft)... 'This cannot be accepted', I said. My view was unanimously endorsed by all present." Advani said they also noticed the "absence of any reference to the Simla accord (1972) and the Lahore declaration (1999)".

Ajay Bisaria, who was Vajpayee's private secretary in 2001, says the Agra Summit "was a necessary step towards closure on Kargil" and "for Vajpayee and his team to understand Musharraf and his proclivities..."

In his autobiography *Relentless*, Yashwant Sinha recalled how things went wrong. "Jaswant Singh had made some changes in his own hand to the typed copy of the draft and had given a photocopy of the amended draft to Sattar. Another copy was brought by him to Vajpayee's room where the rest of us had assembled," Sinha wrote.

Advani, he wrote, pointed out the absence of cross-border terrorism in the draft and Sinha said there were no references to the Simla Agreement. "All this was pointed out to Jaswant Singh as politely as possible, with a request to include these in the draft," Sinha wrote.

A miffed Jaswant Singh said this amounted to no-confidence in him and stormed out of the meeting. Sinha wrote that on Advani's request, he went to Jaswant Singh's room to mollify him, "only to find him in a very glum mood. I tried to reason with him by explaining that there was nothing personal in our approach; we had the highest respect for his abilities and the points we had made were merely suggestions. It was at this stage that the joint secretary in the MEA who oversaw the Pakistan desk, Vivek Katju, walked into the room with a piece of paper to show to Jaswant Singh".

"Singh's mood remained sour and he told Katju that he was not interested in looking at the paper and that perhaps Katju could show it to someone else in the delegation... Being the quintessential civil servant, Katju replied, 'Sir, you are my minister and I can only report to you.' Jaswant Singh did cool down later but by then the negotiations with Pakistan were already in disarray," Sinha wrote.

Advani wrote that "efforts continued at the official level to rework it (the draft) until 4.30 am on 16 July".

The abrupt end

On July 16 morning, just ahead of a scheduled meeting with Vajpayee, Musharraf held a breakfast roundtable with editors of the Indian media, which was broadcast with a brief delay. Jaswant Singh wrote in his book that the President came across as "too belligerent".

Bisaria wrote that they were taken aback. "Musharraf had let loose his hawkish position on Kashmir and equated terrorists with freedom fighters... NSA Brajesh Mishra and I watched the proceedings with dismay."

Bisaria said they quickly typed out a note to brief the PM on what Musharraf had just said. "My arrival interrupted the conversation as both leaders looked up. Musharraf had been talking and Vajpayee was listening, apparently with great interest. I handed over the paper to the boss... After I left the room, Vajpayee looked at the paper and then read out from it to Musharraf, saying edgily that his behaviour was not helping the talks... I was playfully accused by some colleagues of torpedoing the Agra initiative."

In his book, Jaswant Singh wrote, "General Musharraf seemed not to understand the debilitating impact Kargil had had on the atmospherics and also not grasp the essence of what Prime Minister Vajpayee had offered — a new beginning."

Some last-minute efforts were still made. "Musharraf asked for a last meeting with Vajpayee to see if he could save the failing Summit. To Vajpayee, this move had echoes of Bhutto's gambit in Simla in 1972, when he asked for a last call on Indira Gandhi, at a time when the Simla agreement had been deadlocked," Bisaria wrote.

Musharraf left for Islamabad, without visiting Ajmer Sharif. Jaswant Singh, asked if the Indian government prevented him from visiting the shrine, replied: "*Meri kya aukaat ki main unhe Garib Nawaaz ke paas jaane se rokun* (Who am I to stop the Musharrafs from visiting the Dargah)?"

In his version of what transpired, Musharraf wrote in his autobiography *In The Line of Fire*, published in September 2006, "I met Prime Minister Vajpayee at about 11 o'clock at night in an extremely somber mood. I told him bluntly that there seemed to be someone above the two of us who had the power to overrule us. I also said that both of us had been humiliated. He just sat there, speechless."

Advani rejected this as an "outrageous claim" in his book.

Bisaria tells *The Indian Express* that for Vajpayee, the Agra Summit "was a necessary step towards closure on Kargil". "The hope at Agra was to reach that closure. The Summit was also necessary for Vajpayee and his team to understand the Pakistani General and his proclivities... Watching it fail, and persisting, was critical to Vajpayee reaching that closure in January 2004, which bought us a few years of peace, certainly for the next three years... In that sense, the peace he hoped to achieve at Agra did eventually materialise; Agra itself was simply too soon."

In January 2004, Vajpayee and Musharraf met in Islamabad during the SAARC Summit and issued a historic joint press statement with an assurance that no Pakistani territory would be used to support terrorism in India.

25 years later...

PM Modi's first two years in power were marked by overtures towards Pakistan, including the invitation to then PM Nawaz Sharif for his swearing-in in 2014, and his surprise visit to Lahore in December 2015. However, with successive terrorist attacks, in Pathankot, Uri, Pulwama and Pahalgam, the government has hardened its line.

In recent weeks and months, there has been some engagement at the Track-II level and RSS leaders have spoken about the need for an engagement.

On whether talks can happen between India and Pakistan now, Raghavan says, "It doesn't seem very likely, but I always say that with India-Pakistan, you cannot predict because things never follow a linear course. Anything can happen any time."

However, he adds, he does not give much credence to the Track-II talks. "The issues are not people-to-people. The issues are intergovernmental... At a common sense level, obviously everyone will say that there has to be engagement."

Bisaria, who was India's envoy to Pakistan during the Pulwama terror attack and the Balakot surgical strike in February 2019, and was withdrawn after the abrogation of Art 370 in August 2019, adds that climbing back will take a long time. "The longer we go without spectacular terrorism of the Pulwama-Pahalgam level, the greater the chances of some reconciliation. Right now, the trust level is so low that post-Sindoor, the feeling was that the next attack was coming very soon."

However, Bisaria says he "certainly advocates a line of communication with the Pakistan Army, covert or overt, to test whether there is a reasonable guarantee, and a reasonable appetite on the other side, for rapprochement".

Asked about the possibility of another Summit like Agra, Bisaria says: "The Indian political leadership now sees the political cost of a peace initiative as too high. The examples cited are Vajpayee in 1999 repaid with Kargil; Vajpayee again engaging Musharraf at Agra in 2001 and still not succeeding; Manmohan Singh seeing the cost in the 2008 Mumbai terror attack and never risking a Pakistan visit; and Modi paying the price for the 2015 Lahore visit with the Pathankot attack. So politically, it appears too risky — the fear of being caught in a ruse yet again."

If a Summit happens now, Bisaria says, "it will happen only with a sufficient guarantee — direct or indirect, overt or covert — that this time it is for real: that Pakistan wants a genuine conversation and no one will sabotage it with an attack."

WITH VIKAS PATHAK, NEW DELHI

• Before & After Agra

1999

FEBRUARY 20: Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee takes the Sada-e-Sarhad bus to Lahore

FEBRUARY 21: Vajpayee and Pakistani PM Nawaz Sharif sign the Lahore Declaration

MAY 3: Indian troops flag incursions at border, marking the beginning of the Kargil War

JULY 26: India declares Operation Vijay successful

OCTOBER 12: Sharif's civilian government is toppled. Pakistani General Pervez Musharraf takes control of Pakistan

DECEMBER 24-31: After IC-814 hijacking, India releases militants, including Masood Azhar, in exchange for 189 passengers

2000

MARCH 20: 35 Sikh civilians are killed in Chittisinghpura in J&K's Anantnag

DECEMBER 22: 3 shot dead in Red Fort

2001

MAY 23: Vajpayee invites Musharraf for the Agra Summit

JULY 14-16: Agra Summit; talks eventually collapse

OCTOBER 1: 38 killed in J&K Legislative Assembly car bombing

DECEMBER 13: 9 killed in Parliament attack

DECEMBER 19: Operation Parakram begins; India-Pakistan border sees military buildup

2002

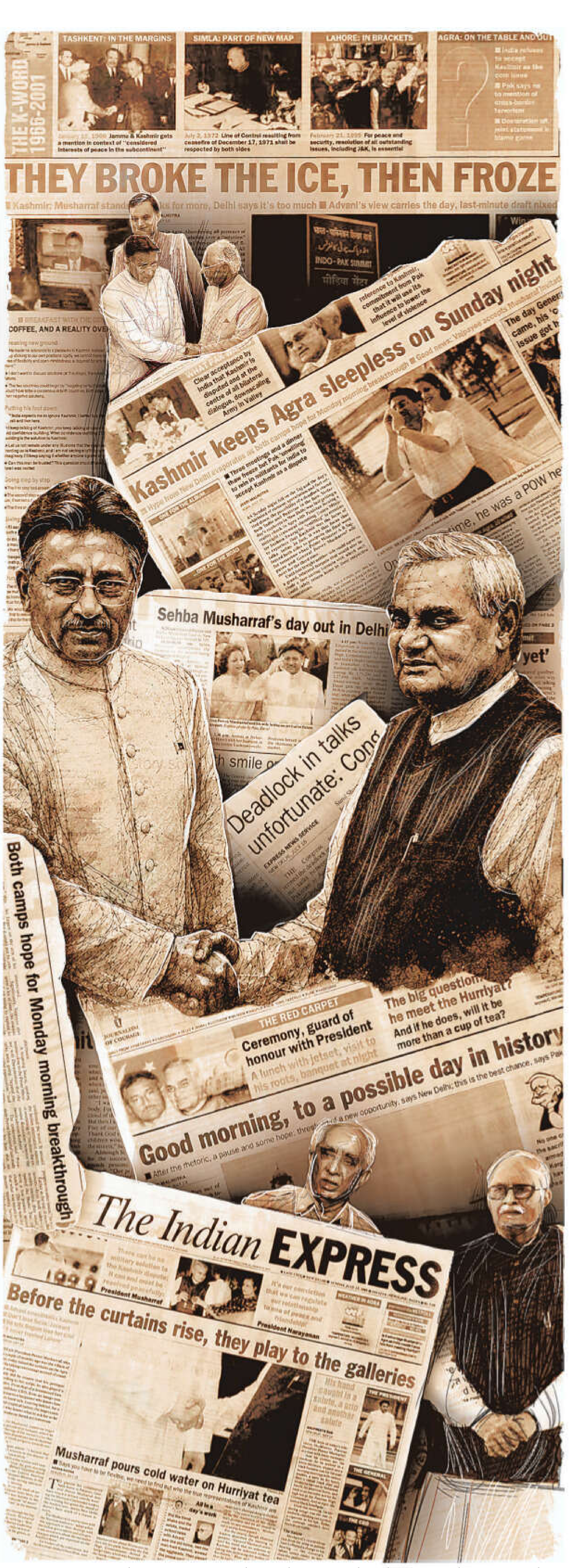
MAY 14: Kaluchak massacre in J&K leaves 31 dead

JUNE 10: India begins to withdraw troops

SEPTEMBER 16-OCTOBER 8: J&K Assembly elections are held

2003

NOVEMBER 25: India, Pakistan enter a ceasefire



• LEGAL

Can courts stop release of a film cleared by CBFC?

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, July 17

THE SUPREME Court on Friday declined to permit the release of the animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath* on its scheduled release date but directed the producer to postpone the release until after July 27, when the annual Rath Yatra in Puri concludes.

The order, by a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and R Mahadevan, came after the Orissa High Court, on July 15, restrained the film's release over concerns regarding the depiction of Lord Jagannath and the possible impact of its screening during the Rath Yatra. The producer had challenged the scope of the High Court's powers, and the extent to which a certified film can be restrained on apprehensions of public disorder.

The HC's order

The High Court held that the film's depiction of Lord Jagannath's childhood and adventures was "not in tune with the religious texts". It said that releasing it during the Rath Yatra would be "counterproductive". The film held three separate 'U' (universal) certificates from the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) for its Hindi, Telugu and Odia versions, dated May, June and July, respectively. The stay stalled the certified Hindi and Telugu versions in states "where no cause of action existed and no relief was ever sought".

THE CASE

- The release of an animated film on Lord Jagannath, which had CBFC certification, was restrained by Orissa High Court.
- The petitioner told the SC that the HC should not override a statutory body's clearance.
- The top court has generally treated CBFC as carrying significant weight.

CBFC certification

The plea states that once "an expert statutory body... certifies (a film) for unrestricted public exhibition, there is a strong legal presumption of validity". Courts should not substitute "its view over the expert wisdom of the CBFC based on unverified apprehensions", it says.

The SC has generally treated CBFC as carrying significant weight. In *Union of India v K M Shankarappa* (2000), it struck down a provision letting the government revise a tribunal's decision. It said that once an expert statutory body certifies a film, that decision cannot be revisited by the executive because of objections or apprehensions about public reaction. It said: "Once an Expert Body has considered the impact of the film on the public and has cleared the film, it is no excuse to say that there may be a law and order situation. It is for the concerned State Government to see that the law and order is maintained." The decisions, the court said, must remain with the process created under the Cinematograph Act.

Similarly, in *S Rangarajan v O Jagjivan Ram* (1989), the Supreme Court held that if a film is otherwise unobjectionable under Article 19(2), "freedom of expression cannot be suppressed on account of threat of demonstration and processions or threats of violence". It said yielding to such threats would amount to the "negation of the rule of law" and that the "state cannot plead inability to handle the hostile audience problem. It is its obligatory duty to prevent it and protect the freedom of expression".

Certification itself, however, is not entirely immune from judicial scrutiny. Courts retain the power to examine whether certification was granted in accordance to the law — such as if the CBFC relied on statutory grounds, issued reasons or followed fair procedure. Where the CBFC acts within the framework of the Act, courts usually defer.

Under the Cinematography Act, the government may suspend or revoke a certification after approval. It may, in some cases, temporarily restrict screening without prior hearing. The Act allows criminal liability for violations and authorities can enter theatres and seize materials.

• POLICY

The case for updating the Indus Waters Treaty

River systems are dynamic entities. Their management, therefore, cannot be static. The 1960 IWT is inadequate to address contemporary challenges

AMITABH SINHA

SEVERAL RHETORICAL statements have emerged from Pakistan in the last couple of weeks over India's decision to keep the Indus Waters Treaty "in abeyance" following the terrorist strikes in Pahalgam last year. Pakistan even organised an "international" conference on the treaty last month, where senior ministers and leaders threatened war and other consequences if the flow of rivers in the Indus basin was disrupted.

Incidentally, Pakistan has still not responded to India's two notices, in 2023 and 2024, to modify and renegotiate the treaty.

While the decision to hold the treaty in abeyance is an exceptional measure to deal with an extraordinary security situation arising from Pakistan's continued support for cross-border terrorism, there is nothing unusual in India's request to amend or renegotiate the treaty. Many other transboundary riverwater-sharing arrangements have built-in provisions for periodic review.

The need for reviewing and updating the Indus Waters Treaty has been articulated, even by Pakistani experts and scholars, for several years now, much before the present stand-off. But India's request for modification or renegotiation of the treaty is the first such official move from either side.

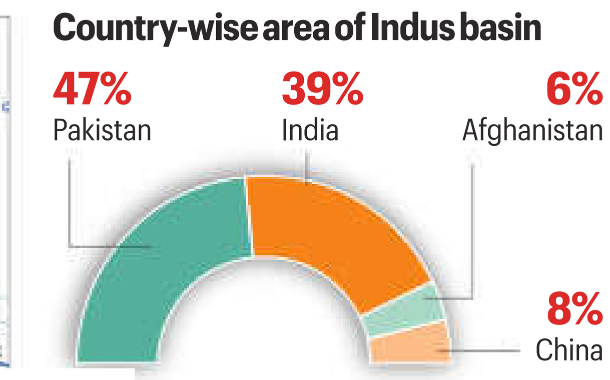
Dynamic systems

River systems are dynamic entities. As river flow and water use changes, the dependent populations increase or decrease, new water management technologies and practices emerge, and better data and scientific knowledge develop. The management of these river waters, therefore, cannot be a static arrangement.

There are at least 250 separate transboundary riverwater-sharing treaties worldwide, covering 113 transboundary river systems, according to a 2013 study. It is unclear how many of these have built-in provisions for review or update. But over time, these treaties gave rise to supplementary protocols, amendments, navigational or data-sharing arrangements, or other cooperative mechanisms, taking the total number of agreements to 688, according to the study.

• THE WAY OF WATER: RIVERS OF THE INDUS BASIN

Country-wise area of Indus basin



RN RIVERS
, Jhelum and Chenab
ivers are for Pakistan's use. India has
eir waters flow "unrestricted" to
n. It can use these waters — even for
on and hydropower, but only in the
r specified in the treaty.

RN RIVERS
Sutlej, Beas and Ravi
The treaty gives India full rights over the waters of the eastern rivers in Punjab. Pakistan can use whatever flows into its territory.

This number now exceeds 800, according to the International Freshwater Treaties database maintained by Oregon State University. This is evidence that many of these treaties are constantly being reviewed and updated to reflect new ground realities.

India's other major transboundary river agreement, the 1996 agreement with Bangladesh on the Ganga, has a 30-year validity. This agreement is due for renewal this year.

While the Indus Waters Treaty is often seen as a static agreement in perpetuity, it is not. Two provisions of the treaty allow it to be adapted to newer situations. Article VII allows the Permanent Indus Commissions of the two countries to undertake new drainage or other engineering works through mutual agreement and cooperation. This provision has never been made use of. Additionally, Article XII provides for modification of the provisions of the treaty "from time to time" but only through another government-level treaty. India has invoked this provision to serve Pakistan notices, seeking its modification or a complete renegotiation.

Review, rework

The agreements governing more than 100 transboundary river systems globally have risen over the years to 800-plus.

This is evidence that many of these treaties are constantly being reviewed and updated to reflect new ground realities.

Many modern riverwater-sharing arrangements, like the one over the Mekong River in Southeast Asia, finalised in 1995, have much more flexible institutional structures and easier processes for making changes. While the Permanent Indus Commission (PIC), established by the Indus treaty, functions merely as its implementing agency, the Mekong River Commission also acts as a joint river water-management system. It cannot change provisions of the original treaty, but is otherwise empowered to develop and revise joint basin management strategies, data-sharing protocols and water quality rules. The PIC has so far largely focused on ensuring that the provisions of the Indus Waters Treaty are not violated.

Inadequate treaty

Even before the present stand-off, it was widely recognised that the Indus Waters Treaty, the result of a unique situation between the two countries in the 1950s, was not adequate to address contemporary water management challenges. This wasn't just about climate change becoming an additional factor. No treaty negotiated before the 1990s could have factored in climate change.

But several other important elements of modern integrated water management practices are also missing from the treaty. For instance, it has no mention of groundwater resources, which, like surface waters, are connected across boundaries.

It also has no provisions for water quality or maintaining environmental flows in the rivers. Pakistan, for example, has repeatedly complained that India dumps a lot of municipal and sewage waste in the eastern rivers over which it has full control under the treaty, and that this adversely affects soil and water health in Pakistan.

These issues are not unique to the Indus Waters Treaty. Most water-sharing arrangements formulated at the time lack these features. However, the difficulties in updating or modifying the Indus Waters Treaty have now become an issue.

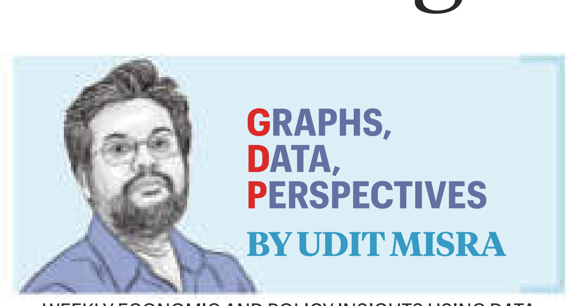
Another way the Indus treaty differs from other riverwater-sharing treaties is the manner in which it allocates water. Most water-sharing agreements ensure the availability of a certain volume of water from the rivers, or a minimum percentage of the flows, for all parties. The Indus Waters Treaty is a rare example of an agreement in which entire rivers have been allocated to one party or the other. That is why it is often described as a partition agreement rather than a sharing arrangement. This kind of clean partitioning of entire rivers is seen as one of the major reasons for the lack of interest in developing joint river basin management programmes.

The case for modifying or renegotiating the treaty is both common-sensical and compelling. A recent study by Indian researchers Vimal Mishra and Urmin Vegad of IIT Gandhinagar showed how climate change was differently affecting water availability in the Indus basin. The basins of the eastern rivers, for instance, have seen a 20% decline in annual rainfall over the last 70 years. Precipitation in the basins of the western rivers has remained largely unchanged.

As it stands, the treaty is leading to inefficient utilisation of the Indus waters, and remains oblivious to the changing needs and demands. India's request to renegotiate the treaty has to be seen as delinked from its decision to put it in abeyance. In fact, agreeing to renegotiate can be the most reliable way for Pakistan to ensure that the treaty is no longer held in abeyance.

• ECONOMY

Will FY27 growth rate rise or fall? Depends on the metric you pick



WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

AMID THE severe economic turbulence brought on by the US and Israel's war against Iran, there is growing concern about whether India will be able to retain its growth momentum. India's economy grew at over 7% in each of the past three years. This figure is crucial because it is the bare minimum needed to achieve the goal of becoming a developed country by 2047.

Factors at play

Over the past few months, the overall economic environment has turned particularly challenging. This can be attributed to:

WAR IN WEST ASIA: This is possibly the most important factor in the short term. India imports 90% of its crude oil and if hostilities heighten further, it could not only lead to crude oil prices rising again but also constrain supply itself.

MONSOON: Even though agriculture only contributes around 17%-18% of India's total economic output, it still engages close to 45% of the population. The spread and quantity of rainfall are not only the biggest determinants for agricultural output but also the key factors that make or break rural household budgets.

TRADE DEFICIT, INVESTMENTS: India's exports have largely been stagnant over the past few years, with higher imports than exports leading to an outflow of foreign exchange. Weakening of foreign investments into India has been a key underlying reason for the slide in the rupee's exchange rate relative to major currencies.

INFLATION AND AFFORDABILITY: A natural corollary of higher crude oil prices is the spike in domestic inflation, affecting purchasing power and domestic growth.

UNCERTAINTY: Sustained levels of uncertainty undermine business confidence and hold back even domestic firms from investing in new capacities (read factories and jobs).

The outlook

India's growth outlook can be read as both better and worse, depending on the variable being examined.

The actual observed variable on the ground is the nominal gross domestic product (GDP). It determines how much money the government can spend and how much it needs to borrow to make up the gap. Generally, another measure is used: real GDP growth, which is essentially the GDP growth rate after taking away the effect of inflation or higher prices.

This year, the nominal GDP growth rate may be higher, even as the real GDP growth rate may falter. Over the past few years, India's nominal GDP has been experiencing deceleration. This has been a matter of concern because it sets the ceiling for real GDP growth. It is also a key determinant in the profitability of India's companies and, as a result, determines the fortunes of stock markets. Thanks to higher inflation, the nominal GDP growth rate is likely to improve this year.

However, most estimates — both international (such as the IMF's recent World Economic Outlook) and national (such as by the Bank of Baroda) — expect a deceleration in the real GDP growth. Most estimates peg India's GDP to grow by anywhere between 6.4% and 6.8%.

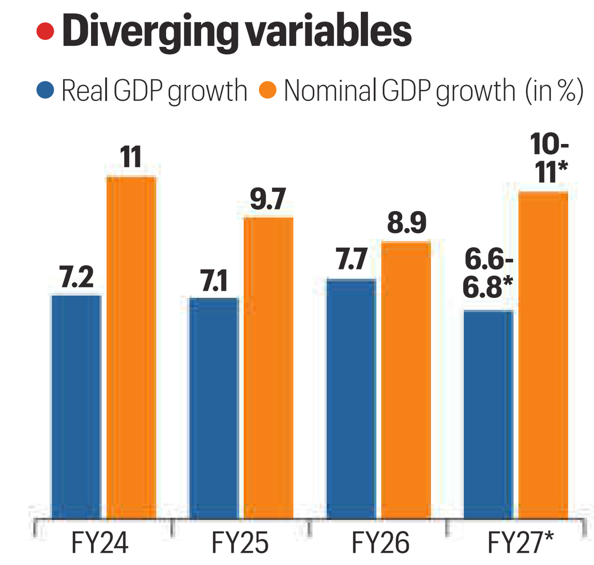
As a recent Bank of Baroda analysis noted, India's manufacturing is likely to register a substantially lower (real) growth rate — from 10.5% in FY26 to 6.5%-7.5% in FY27. A higher base effect and the war's impact on supply chains and overall demand are some contributing factors.

Corporate investments are also expected to grow at a slower pace. India's trade deficit, too, is likely to widen, but thanks to the measures undertaken by the RBI aimed at attracting foreign capital into India, overall Balance of Payments is likely to improve. This, in turn, is likely to provide support for the rupee's exchange rate in the year ahead.

Real vs nominal GDP

- Thanks to higher inflation, the nominal GDP growth rate will likely improve this year.
- However, most estimates expect a deceleration in the real GDP growth — which is essentially the growth rate after taking away the effect of inflation.

• Diverging variables



SOURCE: CEIC, BANK OF BARODA RESEARCH; *ESTIMATES

• HEALTH

Behind US 'explosive diarrhoea' outbreak, hard-to-kill parasite that clings to greens

EXPERT EXPLAINS
DR CYRIAC ABBY PHILIPS
HEPATOLOGIST, CLINICAL SCIENTIST AND PUBLIC HEALTH RESEARCHER

THE US is currently seeing a multi-state outbreak of cyclospora infections. More than 30 states have reported cases this year and current data shows the number surpassing the 2019 record of about 4,700, according to *AP*.

Cyclospora is a microscopic parasite that causes explosive diarrhoea, severe dehydration and hospitalisation. US investigators suspect lettuce at Taco Bell to be the source. **Dr Cyriac Abby Philips**, hepatologist, clinical scientist and public health researcher, speaks to **Rinku Ghosh** about what makes the parasite so dangerous and its status in India.

How can one differentiate cyclospora infections from food poisoning?

The single most useful clue is the duration. Bacterial food poisoning burns itself out in one to three days and viral gastroenteritis in two or three, whereas cyclosporiasis runs for weeks. If left untreated, the illness may last from a few days to a month or longer and may relapse.That rhythm, in which the patient improves, believes it is over, and then crashes again, is close to a signature. The incubation too is long for food poisoning: it averages about a week and ranges from two days to a fortnight or more. If the patient is blaming last night's biryani, it's not cyclospora.

Cyclospora is a protozoan, a single-celled organism that multiplies inside you, while worms are large, multi-celled creatures that cannot directly multiply inside the human body (they lay eggs instead). The features of the illness also differ. The diarrhoea is watery and sometimes explosive, but what dominates is loss of appetite, weight loss, abdominal cramping and bloating, increased flatulence, and a prolonged fatigue extremely out of proportion to the bowel symptoms. The illness is non-inflammatory, so there are no blood and pus cells in the stool.

What about treatment?

Empirical use of antibiotics such as metronidazole, azithromycin or a fluoroquinolone (ciprofloxacin, norfloxacin) will fail, and then co-trimoxazole will produce a dramatic response, which in hindsight is itself a diagnostic. Recognised complications include malabsorption, gallbladder inflammation and reactive arthritis. Any watery diarrhoea persisting beyond two weeks without blood is cyclospora. The important effect is that a routine "stool for ova and parasite" will not find it. The clinician has to specifically request testing for this parasite, or it will simply not be looked for.

Why does it confuse researchers?

Cyclospora cannot be grown in a laboratory culture dish like bacteria, so scientists have to rely heavily on advanced genomic tools to study it. As for why the illness lasts, cyclospora is a tough parasite that hides and multiplies inside the lining of the small intestine, attacking neighbouring cells in waves that cause the illness to return just when doctors think the patient is recovering.

It damages the gut's ability to absorb nutrients, which is why extreme fatigue and weight loss can drag on for weeks even after the diarrhoea has stopped. Furthermore, our body does not develop permanent immunity, meaning a person can catch it again. The parasite is especially dangerous because its "eggs" have a rugged shell and survive for weeks in soil and water, and resist chlorine, allowing it to hitch a ride onto fresh produce.

What about its prevalence in India?

We do not know because almost nobody looks. The most useful record is a 2025 study from the ICMR-National Institute of Cholera and Enteric Diseases in Kolkata, which found C. cayetanensis in around 2% of diarrhoeal patients across eastern India, rising to 7% during July and August, with children aged five to 12 worst affected at 18%. Poor household sanitation and rural residence predict infection.

Why is cyclosporiasis frequently underdiagnosed?

Outbreak investigations face a critical four-to-eight-week reporting-related delay that leaves no fresh produce for testing and relies on flawed recall data. Cyclospora infections are frequently underdiagnosed because the parasite is invisible on standard tests and requires specific staining or ultraviolet fluorescence techniques.

Cyclospora requires time outside the body to become infectious. How does this influence outbreaks?

Cyclospora requires one to two weeks to mature in the environment, making direct person-to-person transmission unlikely. Identifying the parasite on food serves as a "fossil record," indicating contamination happened well before the food was harvested, shipped, or eaten. Consequently, restaurant hygiene protocols are irrelevant; outbreaks stem from environmental contamination upstream, requiring control measures at the farm level.

Are there vulnerabilities in the farm-to-fork supply chain?

Cyclospora is exceptionally skilful at evading food safety systems because it favours raw produce like leafy greens and berries, lacks an effective chemical kill step, and clings tenaciously to complex plant surfaces. Water serves as the primary vector for this parasite, meaning every infection traces back to inadequate sanitation and a lack of toilets. The risk is magnified when contaminated lots are blended into thousands of bags and consumed before short shelf lives expire.While thorough cooking at 70°C is the only absolute kill step, risk reduction depends on farm-level controls like drip irrigation, treated water, worker toilets and strict lot traceability. Consumers can buy whole produce instead of pre-washed salad kits.

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